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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, July 27, 2023

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JQCB9ZRLjbE
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-23. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:13:50] Kim Schatzel: or nine sorry we were having a little bit of tech technical difficulty but i'd like to call this meeting to order and as is customary with this board, I would like for us to begin with a moment of silence, followed by the pledge of allegiance.

[00:14:22] Kim Schatzel: I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America, consider the public for which it stands. Kim Schatzel: nation. Kim Schatzel: This. so it is my understanding that miss holton would like to remove item c from the consent agenda a request which under the board's bylaws we are happy to honor um can i get a motion to approve

[00:14:57] the amended agenda with item c removed from the consent agenda madam president mr sturdifant i'd object to having that removed i think that as a board we have looked at it previously and should continue to keep it um all together without any removal okay um we need presidential i'll make a motion to move it so then we can move to discussion on mr sturdivant's point and hear from

[00:15:27] miss holton thank you second discussion um miss holton i mean mr sturdivant um i look forward to discussing whether we should finalize the action today or not i'll be arguing that we shouldn't and i look forward to a robust conversation on that it was my understanding that it was my prerogative

under the bylaws to have it removed from the consent agenda which does not mean that i mean the board may well decide to finalize it today over my after hearing our discussion so we will

[00:16:04] simply move this item off if this motion passes to from the consent agenda to the other portion of our agenda um so if we could have a vote on that please yeah oh okay we this is actually not a voting piece so we will move on at this point it'll come off and we'll have that vote in in the later portion of the meeting okay um so staff has provided the members of the board with uh the draft minutes we had one request to amend the minutes to reflect the i teach item was approved

[00:16:43] for three years in accordance with the board's guidelines it's my understanding the staff has made that edit so can i get a motion to approve the minutes as amended please all in favor any opposed okay um dr coons this is you so i am really excited that you have um joined us Madam President, as our president of the board and Mr. Bill Henson has been voted in by the board

[00:17:19] to be our vice president. I am grateful for your service to the people of the Commonwealth and your willingness to do that. I also want to introduce our new board members. We have Debbie Kilgore, who is a teacher from former teacher, retired teacher from Southwest Virginia. Very excited to have you on the board as part of our conversation and representing that part of the commonwealth so thank you very much and dr amber northern who is representing our richmond area and i'm very excited to have you as well and we have one board member who's not here so we'll wait to introduce

[00:17:53] her till next month but very excited to move forward with our new board and excited to have our new board in place i just want to mention and highlight that there is a lot of work that goes behind these board meetings and a lot of great staff members so i'm just going to have um jim step into the limelight for just a minute i want to do a special thank you to jim chapman he is our director of board relations and does a great deal of work to put all of these things together under the direct supervision of our assistant superintendent melissa vasquez who is not down

[00:18:28] here right now but the both of them do a whole lot of work to get us organized and um in place she has luckily stepped in so she can come up and say good morning um i just want to thank these two tireless staff members for doing all the great work to get us organized and get us together for this work and really keep us rolling so thank you guys very much um we have several new staff members at the department of education so i just want to mention that dr marcy sorenson has taken the position of deputy superintendent of teaching and learning she is not with us this morning she

[00:19:07] is out in the field so very much appreciate her willingness to do that and then erica brody has come on as the director and superintendent operations just want to give everybody a face with the name because she is doing wonderful work to operationalize and organize the superintendent's office so very excited to have erica as well um we have been talking a great deal about elevating our teachers in the virginia department of education and thinking intentionally about the work our teachers are doing very excited that we have put 29 million dollars to programs to

[00:19:46] elevate the teaching profession and bring more teachers into our classrooms so that we have a high quality licensed teacher for every k-12 child in the state of virginia those grants really focus on a grow your own approach which allow our school divisions to work collaboratively with their communities and think about what are the best candidates for teachers in their communities so very excited about that work and that work moving forward. We are also digging into artificial intelligence and working on how to support our teachers and our educators to incorporate those

[00:20:24] things into the classroom and are partnering with ISTE and hopefully we'll be having guidance soon to help our educators focus on the changing world in post-pandemic and learn from the tools we use during that time period and integrate those into the classroom.

[00:20:40] We are also in the process of going through math standards adoption and very excited. We've had a lot of public comment, a lot of feedback in meetings, and want to thank the board for attending those open sessions and giving us feedback. We have also had experts from Virginia ask us to review those standards, give us feedback on those math standards and want to complement the team under the direction of Tina Mazkane, who is leading the revisions based on public comment and really excited to be moving forward with rigorous math standards that help our students prepare for the career and workforce and opportunities that they have post K-12.

[00:21:19] So very excited about the work happening at the department, very excited about moving forward. I think the board also had a great conversation during our retreat about our accountability and accreditation system,

[00:21:31] And we will continue to work on those focuses as well as the standards of quality discussions that we had and bring a large amount of presentations in front of the state school board over the next several months to think about what our standard of quality are, what kinds of things we need to continue to do to support quality in our classrooms, and how do we communicate that through our accountability and accreditation system and really modernizing that system to think about what is accountability.

[00:22:01] how do we communicate that to families? How do we make sure our families understand how our schools are doing? But also in accreditation, thinking about what kind of inputs go into our schools and what kind of programming our schools are offering for our students across the Commonwealth.

[00:22:16] And then thinking about how do we support our schools? What is the support structures that actually happen when we think about accountability? If our schools need more support, how do we support them? And we've been working at the department redesign our office of school quality i'm excited to announce that we have a new assistant superintendent brendan albin who has a deep bench and experience in instruction and we be able to lead that instructional support for our school divisions that need the most support and then our accountability and accreditation system defines what kinds of support they need so excited to move forward with a lot of these important initiatives and excited to turn it over

[00:22:56] today i hope you will can join me in congratulating our new board members our madam president um mr vice president who is on our zoom call today and i'm going to turn it over to you madam president thank you very much mr hansen would you like to say a few words mr hansen would you like to say a

[00:23:30] few words amanda was that mr hard time hearing would you like to say a few words about our new positions or yes yes thank you um well i'm just very grateful for the trust in the fellow board members and i'm just grateful to serve our families and teachers and students in the commonwealth and

[00:24:01] just appreciate really our new board members as well and just the sacrifice and the strength and perspective that you all bring to helping us really be about the work of our students so just thank you for the opportunity and grace just madame president uh grateful to be at your side and help him do whatever i can to make the work of the the board as efficient as possible thank you

[00:24:36] um just just as my own comments um i would just like to say that i was humbled by the opportunity and the trust that my fellow board members have given me in this position because what i can tell you is in 2001 when i entered the doors of maury high school in norfolk virginia as a first year teacher i never thought that i'd be sitting here today but what i'd want to say to all of those teachers first year or beyond please keep doing what you're doing we need you and then we need

[00:25:11] you to love your profession as deeply as i love this profession um i cannot thank the teachers of the commonwealth enough for what they do every single day for our students for our schools for our families for our communities and for our great commonwealth and so with that i would just like to say that i look forward to us all working hand in hand to accomplish what needs to be accomplished to ensure that every student in the commonwealth gets the education that they deserve and that

[00:25:49] is our mission that is our passion and that is what's driving the work that we do every single day um just at this time i would like to ask miss kilgore and dr northern if they would like to say anything um as our newer board members here today miss kilgore okay um thank you and welcome everybody here i would say what our friends stated when she first began teaching she didn't think she would be sitting on this board someday when i retired a year ago as an educator 36 years in cte

[00:26:23] in high in secondary cte um i never knew never thought about you know i wasn't looking to be on board but when i was called and asked to serve on the board it reminded me of many times i would say to my students that all of us are going to be asked some time in our life to lead we won't all be elected but we will all be asked to lead so i would have been a little hypocritical if when i was asked to take this position if i said no so i'm honored i've learned a lot in the past two days and today and i'm looking forward to working with this board and we're looking forward to serving

[00:26:57] our commonwealth for our children thanks dr northern yeah i feel like i'm going to echo some of these thoughts i started as a teacher at norview high school um and absolutely loved my time at norview high school marjorie staley was the principal back then she was you know five feet two or something uh she used to wear heels this this tall um and she was an impressive and commanding figure and um we we did some great things at norview high school back then and and we didn't have air conditioning back then it was uh it was pretty hot i remember the you know the

[00:27:33] kids and i would you know open the windows turn off the lights and everybody could you know drink water um but anyway it feels like it's come full circle today um to be on this board to be to be sitting here and to stare out among you so i just i'm honored by this opportunity to serve my home state. So thank you. Okay. Yes, Ms. Alton. I ask for just a moment of personal privilege both to welcome the new board members and to thank you and Mr. Hansen for being willing to step up to serve.

[00:28:08] We all talk and we all believe that this is the hardest working board, volunteer board in the Commonwealth of Virginia and maybe in the nation. But to be in the leadership roles is even harder, I know, and your predecessor, as you know, set a very high bar, and I know you will reach and surpass it.

[00:28:28] Your experience as both a classroom teacher in Norfolk and Goochman, but also in administrative roles will have brought already invaluable experience to this board. And frankly, your work helping your work at the Council on Private Education, where you've worked with preschools at such an extensive preschool management world, policy world so much has already been invaluable to our work, bringing early childhood education under the purview of the Department of Education. And I just, I'm so grateful that we have you in our

[00:29:05] leadership role and wanted to take the chance to say that. Thank you so much. President, I'd like to follow on that and say the same thing and just add in the time we've worked together. I mean, You do, you know, Ms. Holton just mentioned you've worked in the early ed sector, you work with private schools, you work with public schools, you've had the ability to range across the different parts of our sector, which is extremely important right now, and just to work, I've watched you work effectively across lines of difference, you bring a seriousness of purpose, as well as an empathy to this, and it's just really exciting to see this next stage for the board.

[00:29:37] Thank you. I think I would be remiss if I did not just say that we all miss President Gecker and his command leadership of this board, but I will do everything I can to honor what he has laid for us here.

[00:29:55] The one thing I would like to take a minute of business, as is customary, I have approved by way of the bylaws that Mr. Hanson is participating with us electronically today. And so we would like to move to some recognitions at this time.

[00:30:13] So I hope everybody can hear me. Every year, the Virginia Association of Secondary School Principals honors three principals who represent the very best of educators in Virginia schools. these individuals work diligently, lead selflessly, and serve tirelessly. You guys are the ones that get the calls in the middle of the night that the boiler's not working in the building, and the air condition's broken, and everybody's going to swelter tomorrow. I mean, those are the times

[00:30:48] that you kind of stress over. But thank you all for your service to our schools. And the Board of Education, sets policies for schools across the state, but these principles are going way above and beyond. They implement a vision for public education in Virginia and shape so many different lives in the process from those that they lead from an instructional standpoint to the students that are in their buildings every day. We are incredibly honored to have them join

[00:31:23] us today. And Mr. Sturdifant, I think you are going to be introducing our first guest. So if you would go to the podium, please. Madam President, Vice President Hansen, fellow board members, Superintendent Coombs, it is my pleasure to introduce the 2023 Outstanding Secondary

[00:31:49] Assistant Principal today. Mr. Diggs, please come up. The Outstanding Secretary Assistant secondary school assistant principal 2023 is Mr. Benjamin Diggs of Stafford County Public Schools.

[00:32:22] Mr. Diggs has been an educator for 11 years. Mr. Diggs grew up in Stafford, where he currently works before attending Virginia Tech for his undergraduate degree. There are a lot of Virginia Tech go Hokie people here. For his undergraduate degree, Mary Washington University for his master's, and Old Dominion University for his educational specialist degree, and pre-K through 12 administration and supervision he began his career as a substitute bus driver then became a substitute teacher person and had his first full-time position as a counseling center

[00:32:57] administrative assistant some of mr digg's favorite memories from his past school year are the school bus runs he would do for after school activities and how students will get excited to ride his bus nailed this in addition to his responsibilities as an assistant principal what a fun example of his dedication to his students and ensuring that their educational experience extends beyond the classroom over the next year mr diggs would like to see instruction and learn and continue to improve so that he can see his students succeed and even more on their

[00:33:34] journey through graduation and into their adult lives this part here touched me each morning he tells his students this if no one has told you today let me be the first to tell you that i love you and we love you at stafford high school he has seen how this has a positive impact on school culture and climate and he has learned that he may be the only adult which is very true in his students lives that sees them and tells them that they are loved please join me in welcoming

[00:34:11] and honoring mr benjamin dix very honored today miss holton i believe you have our second guest I'm delighted to recognize here, to welcome to the podium here today, our 2023 Outstanding Middle School Principal, Ms. Champrese Bevelle of ASAD's sixth grade campus.

[00:34:56] This year's Outstanding Middle School Principal is Ms. Champrese Bevelle. She grew up in the Bronx, New York. She graduated from Norfolk State with a bachelor's in biology before earning her master's in education from cambridge college and an ed s in administration leadership from the george washington university she has been with virginia city virginia beach city public schools for six years seven years she has two favorite memories from the school year the first is when her students kept running to her with excitement to tell her their scores on a mock sol reading test she will

[00:35:33] never forget how proud and confident they were a good education will provide that for students the second is when she found out that her school was being awarded as a 2022 national distinguished school by esea network your goal for next year i understand is continued academic progress and i guess i should say this year as we're here right almost and to inspire a sense of belonging that empowers educational and emotional outcomes. We would like to add that we also found out just last week that Ms. Bavelle is one of three national finalists for the 2024 National Association of

[00:36:13] Secondary School Principals Principal of the Year Award. We cannot be prouder of how you are representing excellence in Virginia. We're excited to have you here with us today and to congratulate Dr. Hanson, I mean Dr. Siebert, I think you have our last one, and I would just say thank you.

[00:36:44] My last years in the classroom were in middle school, so that is a special place for a lot of very special people. I have a middle schooler living in my house right now, and I'm not sure if I recognize her, so maybe she'll come out on the other end.

[00:37:02] other end thank you dr siebert uh good morning it is in my pleasure to have the opportunity to introduce our 2023 outstanding high school principal if i could ask mr howard townsend the fourth please come forward uh from peace principal at jamestown high school so welcome and congratulations mr townsend graduated from tab high school in yorktown before attending the college of william and mary for his bachelor of arts degree in education he has been in education for 26 years 15 of which he spent as an english teacher track and field cross-country coach at his school his current school he's been the principal of jamestown for five years mr towns's favorite

[00:37:41] moment from this school year was the jamestown high school spring fest which is an event coordinated by the community in conjunction with school clubs he loved the sense of belonging togetherness at the event he especially enjoyed watching teachers students parents doing the cha-cha slides and even being together at one point when they even more people gathered and parents joined in the dance mr townsend's goal for the coming year is to find more ways to honor and celebrate the different ways in the many different disciplines in which different children excel and achieve ladies and gentlemen please join me in welcoming and celebrating mr howardy townsend the fourth

[00:38:17] mr chapman are we going to do a picture please come forward all awardees

[00:38:53] Ann and Gail, you guys can come down in the same direction. Ann, you guys help present. I want the tall guy beside me. Nice to meet you. Thank you. Thank you very much.

[00:39:09] Oh, wow. Congratulations. Thank you.

[00:39:16] thank you all so much appreciate it thank you for your service

[00:39:55] thank you thank you thank you so much congratulations former middle school middle school thank you yeah thank you very much appreciate it so nice congratulations congratulations

[00:40:24] okay so apparently i have to be a little bit more formal mr hansen is participating today remotely because he is greater than 60 miles away from this meeting and i have so approved that participation okay so we will begin the section of the meeting with public comment as stated in the board's bylaws it is the pleasure of the board to accept public comment on all matters related to public

[00:41:01] education in virginia we ask that you please provide your name and affiliation at the beginning of your remarks speakers will limit speakers will limit their comments to three minutes we are going to um experiment a little bit today with a new timekeeping mechanism so you will notice the timer on the screens when once once public comment begins as you can see our beautiful timers three minutes is green at one minute the screen will turn yellow and the screen will turn

[00:41:39] red when time is up when your time is up please close your remarks promptly out of respect for the rest of those who would like to speak so speakers should provide copies any copies that need to come to the board please provide them um to miss sonia brody who is sitting right here in in the lovely pink sweater um sonia can you raise your hand so everybody can see you yes and also if you could please um email a copy of your remarks to jim chapman who is our director

[00:42:14] of board relations after you finish speaking so our first speaker on the list today is candace Lucas. Lucas? Good morning, Newport members. My name is Candace Lucas. Can you hear me? My name is Candace Lucas. I'm a licensed educator, licensed administrator, specializing in special education.

[00:42:43] Right now, I'm completing my dissertation regarding the trauma that Black mothers experience as they navigate the special education system throughout Virginia, which is akin to the time period in which we were enslaved okay so i i'll look forward to giving you that dissertation i've come i've probably been here longer than all of you except for miss holton yeah you and i've been around a while but i've attended all of the meetings to bring uh sound the alarm regarding special education and the fact that special education is in a crisis many of you do not know

[00:43:20] that IDEA, the Individuals with Disabilities Educational Act, is a civil rights law. And as a Black woman, I'm very sensitive to the issue of civil rights. In Virginia, there is a massive resistance effort to completely dismantle IDEA for profit. Now, we've all seen the trailer for the movie "Sound of Freedom" and how the issue of sex trafficking of children is prominent and probably one of the most profitable profitable criminal conspiracies in the world where i'm here to talk to you about sound of education where student trafficking in virginia is one of the

[00:43:58] most profitable criminal conspiracies in the commonwealth and i'm not making this up all you have to do is look at goochton's budget richmond city's budget chesterfield's budget i've examined all of them for the last seven years and in each of them money is being funneled from educational stakeholders

to private predatory law firm shareholders. That's my money, our money for our children. Now, we are very concerned that this board has been silent. This superintendent

[00:44:33] has been silent. No one is interested in saving the lives of children that are dying. And once again, when we look at the movie, The Sound of Freedom, our children want to be educated. All children with disabilities deserve to be educated. And the issue that they are not being educated and the parents that advocate for them are being targeted and are being treated as though they're enslaved secondary citizens in this commonwealth is sickening. And Dr. Coons, you're fully aware of what's going on. You get the emails. I send you about 15 emails every day. And I get the same

[00:45:11] uh the same package response uh that you guys uh thought you go ahead and file a complaint through a system that is broken because special education is broken and because it is broken we need to fix it the same people that broke it cannot fix it so we're waiting to see what you're going to do about that before our children continue to die thank you kathy halverson followed by melissa siddiqui

[00:45:38] please. Good morning, President, Madam President, and Mr. Handsome, Dr. Coons, and new board members, all board members. This is my son. I need to put a face to my son. He has been out the second page

[00:46:08] 624 days out of school. November 17th, we were in an IEP meeting, and it clearly stated everybody agreed that he needed private placement. They were unable to educate him due to behaviors.

[00:46:27] I had him tested. He is diagnosed with being a savant. They had him in a class, the same classroom. In first grade, he was in fifth. He was in the same fifth grade classroom for three years in a row. Three years in a row. Only thing changed was students.

[00:46:44] This also, November 18th, agreed to private placement. Home-based services. Speech services. They placed him in home-based. No teacher ever showed. Never got speech therapy. Stated on December 1 count, they received the money.

[00:47:11] The next page is CSA. It states, I will not open a CSA. So in doing so, the school division is responsible. That's from CSA president. Another one stating I'm compliant, that I do not have to open up a CSA agreement. School division is responsible. Karen Gobble, the next one, shows

[00:47:45] she sent all the paperwork to Believe in You Academy for private placement. Everybody was in agreement to private placement at BNU. And all these other ones, CSA, school divisions responsible.

[00:48:03] February 16, 2022, Lynn Prince on page 30 stating, a parent does not have to sign a CSA agreement. We are responsible. Same thing. I'm compliant. Everything's I'm compliant.

[00:48:20] school divisions responsible. They pay for private placement. There's a charter house bill from another student. And I'll take you to the last since I'm almost done. This is the judge.

[00:48:38] This is a transcript from the false chins that they filed against me and my husband charging us. It was dismissed. What's this say right here? It states this has nothing to do about a child and supervision. This is who pays. Thank you, Ms. Alverson. Please send a contract. My son is Melissa Siddiqui, followed by Wendy Little, please. Is Melissa Siddiqui here?

[00:49:12] How about Wendy Little? Wendy Little, Cheryl Sims, followed by Scott Brabrand. Good morning. My name is Minister Cheryl Sims. I didn't come to take up a lot of your time, but I came to ask for your help. I live in Goodsland, Virginia, and I have two

[00:49:52] severely disabled grandchildren they're not only severely disabled they're traumatized they would miss their mom in june of 2021 be murdered right in front of their eyes i'm trying to keep my composure it's sad that i have to come here and plead for help for children that their life speaks volume i shouldn't have to shout from a rooftop but i am and i'm going to because i'm their biggest advocate i'm their biggest fan i love my grandkids i want the best for them i wish this hadn't

[00:50:25] happen to them but i can't turn back the hands of time nobody can we can only move forward this is car and this is cruel they need your help and your file you'll find a medicine log all the medicine they take they can't even sleep at night they cry they wet the bed they have nightmares since 2021 it's not going to go away it's not getting any better but the school says we won't accept medical directives from professionals that they've been tested by they said we won't accept them we're

[00:51:00] going to go by educational standards and that should that law needs to change today because if a doctor can pinpoint the cause then the school should respect that so you mean to tell me if he's a diabetic you're going to say and i'm a diabetic that's why i'm speaking on you're going to say i'm not going to give you your medicine so only two things can happen to a diabetic if you don't give them their medicine the sugar drop very low and they go in a coma or go very high they go in a coma. So you mean to tell me these children with the severe condition that takes medicine two times a day to manage in the daytime and they'll sleep, and most of the time they still

[00:51:37] don't sleep at night. Doctors are still increasing their medicine, still adding medicine. I have to go pick up a new one today because they are uncontrollable. And the school knows this, but they cover it up. And that's disgusting. I have been retaliated on. I got served at no trespass by Jeremy Riley out in Goochland, Virginia. And I think he works for you now.

[00:51:57] Am I right, Ms. Kuhn? He served me with a no trespass. A police officer came to my house and served me. I'm a minister of the gospel of Jesus Christ. I have never been in trouble a day in my life. Do you know how gut-wrenching and hurting and traumatizing that is? You'll see a prior written notice. You'll see a story about Emmett Till, how he got falsely accused. I've been falsely accused. And that's a shame. And we see what happened to him. That won't happen to me on my grandkids and took the face of the murderer he took my grandchildren's mother's life and he

[00:52:32] took his own he was a coward he didn't even want to go to court he did all kind of heinous things to my grandchildren mentally physically sexually he subjected them to watch horror movies day in and day out they told me when they came to see me grandma can we see penny wise i said i don't know yes we appreciate it can i do really one thing and then i'll get out of you unfortunately we only have three minutes for each speaker we need to move into our agenda so we have a long list of speakers today we will certainly miss sims can you make sure that sonia gets a copy of that folder so we have a copy for the department record i want to make sure i have a copy and guys please

[00:53:08] read this poem thank you because i'm standing in a gap now for the mom she said she can't carry on but i can and i will please thank you thank you um scott raybrand followed by jeremy bennett please good morning superintendent superintendent coons and members of the board of education my name is scott bray brand and i'm the executive director for the virginia association of school superintendents first i want to welcome uh dr northen miss hill gore and miss ashen to the board of education

[00:53:47] we thank you and your colleagues for your service to the commonwealth i also want to congratulate Ms. Creasy as President and Mr. Hansen as Vice President, and we congratulate you on your new leadership roles. Secondly, I want to continue to express my appreciation to Superintendent Coons for including Virginia superintendents in the discussion around the future of accountability and accreditation in Virginia. We look forward to continuing to partner with her and to share with her our input and insights into this important work. We appreciate her deliberative and collaborative

[00:54:24] approach to these important policies. VAS will continue to emphasize the importance of growth in any future accountability and accreditation system as a major factor in that system's construction. We also applaud the board for reviewing today and moving forward the status of school construction funds. The physical state and condition of many of our schools in Virginia are simply not acceptable, and there's been tremendous demand from superintendents and school districts for these funds. VAS appreciates that this remains a board priority and hopes that

[00:55:01] the board can move forward with releasing these remaining funds as soon as is feasible after the board has a review. Finally this morning, VAS has sent all of you a letter inviting you to our fall conference here in Richmond this October. Several members of our board of education last fall joined us for a panel discussion to talk about the important work that you all are doing this year and to share it with superintendents who ultimately are responsible for implementing those policies and procedures with school boards in Virginia school districts. We hope that many

[00:55:37] of you will have the opportunity to join us this fall for that discussion. Thank you for your leadership and service and have a great morning. Thank you. Jeremy Bennett followed by Cardell

[00:55:53] Patio. Good morning, President Creasy, members of the Board, Superintendent Coons. My name is Jeremy Bennett, representing the Virginia Association of Counties, VACO. First of all, allow me to congratulate President Creasy and Vice President Hansen on your election to the Board, and also congratulations to the newest appointees to the Board, who I haven't had a chance yet to meet personally.

[00:56:22] I come here today to speak to you about the 2023 Biennial Review of the Standards of Quality, the SOQs. As you're aware, the Constitution of Virginia requires the Board to prescribe SOQs for the public schools of Virginia, subject to revision only by the General Assembly, and to do this process as required by code every two years.

[00:56:42] Given their role as funding partners in education, these standards are of great interest to county governments across the state, and Virginia Association of Counties stands ready to assist the Board and the Department of Education in their efforts to prescribe meaningful education policy to the General Assembly.

[00:56:59] I provided Ms. Brody with a letter from VACO's Executive Director, Dean Lynch, highlighting these priorities and VACO's willingness to contribute to this process. I just want to reiterate that VACO stands ready to assist you and your staff in these discussions and looks forward to opportunities to participate in the SOQ review process.

[00:57:17] And I'll conclude by saying thank you for your service to Virginia, working to build a robust state of partnership and support of public education across the Commonwealth. Thank you. Cardell Petillo, followed by Harry Jackson, please. Morning, sir. Good morning. Good morning to President Creasy, Vice President Hanson, members of the Virginia Board of Education, and Dr. Coombs.

[00:57:48] I'm Cardiel Fotillo and it's an honor to address you today as the President-Elect of the Virginia School Boards Association. On behalf of VSBA, I would like to congratulate President Creasy and Vice President Hansen. I would also like to extend a warm welcome to new board members Ms. Kilgore, Dr. Northern, and Ms. Ashton.

[00:58:05] VSBA is excited for the opportunity to continue our partnership with the board. Today I'm here to discuss the Board Agenda IMD dealing with the request for guidance on the School Construction Assistance Program program and the board's consideration of program changes.

[00:58:20] VSBA is appreciative of the monies appropriated by the Virginia General Assembly in the 2022-24 biennium budget and work done by the department staff to distribute the monies to our school divisions. VSBA would like to make the following recommendations of the board regarding item E.

[00:58:38] We asked the board to consider item E on first preview with final preview to be heard at the September meeting of the board to allow for school divisions to provide feedback to the Department of Education staff on the application and rubric for the grant. Additionally, BSBA asked the board to delay found reviews of item E to the September meeting of the board to allow for potential action by the Virginia General Assembly to additional revisions to the 22-24 budget.

[00:59:06] Each chamber's budget contains revisions that allow additional flexibility and criteria used in the grant application. We have included these budget revision items on the second page as an addendum to these remarks. VSBA believes stakeholder feedback and recent reports of a potential breakthrough and further revisions to the budget that include further flexibilities to localities seeking the construction grant warrant the board to hear item E on first preview today with final review at the September board meeting.

[00:59:36] We respectfully request this action of the board and are ready to give feedback to department staff on the grant application as it's reviewed. Finally, I would like to take this opportunity to thank Dr. Coons and her staff for meeting with the VSBA Executive Committee last week.

[00:59:52] The meeting was productive and we look forward to future conversations as we work to continue to improve Virginia's public education system. I appreciate the opportunity to speak with you today, and I wish you a productive July meeting on the board. Thank you. Thank you so much. Harry Jackson, followed by Sharon Sutt. Is Harry Jackson here? No? Sharon Sutt?

[01:00:27] Good morning, Madam President, Vice President Hanson, members of the board, Superintendent Combs. My name is Sharon Supp, and I'm here today on behalf of the Promise to America's Parents Coalition, a coalition of 40 grassroots and policy groups which advocate for the fundamental right of parents to direct the upbringing, education, and care of their children. The Promise Coalition represents the concerns of racially, religiously, and politically diverse parents in every state in the nation. The coalition unites parents, community leaders, faith leaders, and lawmakers in order to protect the rights of parents to lead and guide their children, because parents and not

[01:01:05] the government know and love their children best. On behalf of the Promise Coalition, we wish to sincerely thank Governor Youngkin and the Board of Education for promulgating common sense model policies which were recently released, which protect the safety, privacy, and dignity of all students while acknowledging the essential role that parents play as the primary decision makers and caregivers for their children. The Promise to America's Parents Coalition consists of 10 principles which provide a

roadmap for sound laws and policies that properly respect parental rights through accountability, choice, and transparency. Parents have the right to know what is going on

[01:01:44] with their child's education, the right to choose whether their child shares a bathroom or locker room with students of the opposite sex, and the right to know whether their child is called by different names and pronouns while at school. Virginia's new model policies are a prime example of how the promises core principles of accountability, choice, and transparency can be incorporated into state education policies in order to safeguard children by ensuring that their parents are not excluded from important decisions involving their child's education or physical or mental health. The U.S. Constitution, the Virginia Constitution, and the Code of Virginia protect the fundamental right of parents to direct their children's upbringing, education, and care. By

[01:02:24] By working diligently to develop these new model policies while welcoming input from citizens, parents, grassroots groups, advocacy organizations, I'm sorry, organizations, and community and faith leaders, Governor Youngkin and the Board of Education have demonstrated their true care and concern for all public school students by securing meaningful parental involvement in critical decisions involving a student's education and health.

[01:02:47] The Governor and the Board have also demonstrated their true care and concern for all parents of public school students by acknowledging and preserving the long-recognized right of parents to raise and direct their children, and by empowering parents to make informed decisions in the best interest of the child with which they have been entrusted.

[01:03:06] The Promise Coalition applauds Governor Youngkin and the Board of Education for recognizing the vital role that parents play in their children's lives, for preserving fair competition for female athletes, for protecting the privacy of all students in intimate school facilities like bathrooms and locker rooms, and for ensuring that all students are treated with dignity and respect. Lastly, the coalition commends these common sense policies to other governors and education boards around the country who wish to prioritize the privacy, dignity, and respect of all students while honoring the valuable and essential role parents have. Thank you for your

[01:03:40] comments. Zach Ritz, followed by Tyson Langhofer. Is Zach Ritz here? Sorry, I can't see around the corner. My name is Zach Ritz and I'm the pastor of Veritas Church in Warrington, Virginia. As a parent and as a pastor of many families in Warrington, I commend you for your bravery and your fidelity in protecting our constitutional rights, adopting the model policies of Governor

[01:04:18] Glenn Youngkin. Now these policies I believe defend our unity of our families, not only of our families but also as virginians and even as americans you know the lord said a house divided against itself and that's right this divide and conquer strategy has been used since the garden of eden when satan sought to divide mankind from god and also from one another right and he succeeded however god sent his son jesus who died for our sins so that we might be reunited to god and to

[01:04:54] one another you see king jesus stood opposed to the kingdom of darkness he waged war against satan sin and death he was victorious he rose from the dead on the third day he's now seated at the right hand of god the father and he then sent his church to go tell all nations including ours that jesus is now king of all kings and lord of all lords now in our generation communism has sought to divide and conquer just like satan you see this is why president eisenhower called upon congress

[01:05:31] to add the words remember under god to the pledge of allegiance and we've all grown up now putting our hands on our hearts pledging allegiance is to stand united while communist ideologies though have have crept in they've slithered into the hearts and minds of many seeking to do what to divide us now if our nation is to be united it must be properly divided for just as light cannot be united with darkness good cannot be united with evil it's time to make good on our pledge

[01:06:07] to remain united as one nation under god against the attacks and the ideologies of an enemy seeking to divide our families and our nation now you have done your part in adopting these model policies and defending our families and our constitutional rights i thank you for that and may the rest of the nation rally behind the Virginians and may God bless America as we remained united under his son. In the name of the Father, of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen. Tyson Langhofer followed

[01:06:43] by Sarah Horst. Morning Madam President, members of the board. Thank you for the opportunity to testify. My name is Tyson Langhofer. I'm senior counsel with Alliance Defending Freedom. I'd like to offer two brief points in support of the Department of Education's 2023 model policies.

[01:07:01] First, treatment consistent with sex is not discrimination based on gender identity. Probably the most common claim opposing a policy like the 2023 model policies is that if schools don't actively participate in students' social transition by using new names and pronouns or allow access to locker rooms and sports teams based on identity, then the school is discriminating based on gender identity.

[01:07:26] This is not true. Article 1, Section 11 of our Commonwealth's Constitution says in black and white, mere separation of the sexes shall not be considered discrimination. And it's not just our law. This reflects basic logic about how discrimination works. To test for whether discrimination is based on a characteristic as present, you only have to ask, does that characteristic change the way someone is treated? If the answer is no, there's no discrimination.

[01:07:54] Take pronouns, for example. A teacher is not discriminating based on gender identity. If she declines to personally participate in a student's social transition by using pronouns to address a male child as she or her. That's because she wouldn't address any male child, regardless of gender identity, as she or her. And it's easy to imagine such a request from a non-transgender student. A male student might come and say, I'm male and I identify as male, but I would like to be called she, her pronouns out of solidarity for my transgender classmates. The teacher would still

[01:08:28] decline. The gender identity of the student plays no role. Consistent treatment based on sex is not discrimination based on gender identity. Second, the 2023 model policies take the right of hurt by protecting the interests of all those in our school communities. In our country, the Constitution protects the right to differ as to things that touch the heart of the existing order, specifically in America's public schools. Are there any questions so near to the heart of order than who am i what is a man what is a woman the 2023 model policies choose accommodation

[01:09:06] over coercion when addressing this sensitive topics students may identify as they wish but schools will not actively facilitate their social transition without parental involvement students need not use any particular restroom but they may not necessarily access every restroom all students will have the opportunity to play sports but sports is a contest about bodies not identities all of this safeguards students respects parents protects teachers and preserves the school's role of educating children and fitting them to live as free citizens in a plural society thank you

[01:09:42] very much sarah horst followed by virginia gentles sarah horst here hey virginia gentles no morning my name is jenny gentles i'm the director of the independent women's forum

[01:10:18] education freedom center and i'm also the mother of two former arlington public school students like many virginia families we left the public school system because we no longer trust our residentially assigned schools to educate our children too many elements of the virginia public school system prioritize activism over academics for example the activist drafted march 2021 model policies require teachers to address children by their ever-shifting array of pronouns abolish sex-specific facilities and even choirs organized by sex encourage schools to develop secretive action plans to support the student's transition and consider reporting parents who

[01:10:55] affirm their child's biological sex to child protective services activists regularly claim that parents can't be trusted presuming that they will harm their children yet the presumption should be that parents can and should be involved from their children's lives and that their children their children are loved these parents love their children i support the 2023 model policies which protect children from government employees who want to require school staff to deceive parents and encourage young women to medicalize their insecurities. Pressuring a child to choose a new identity and name and then hiding the child's social transition from her parents is

[01:11:31] manipulative and cruel. The Virginia schools that will insist on following the 2021 model policies teach children from young ages that they may have been born in the wrong body. This is confusing and destabilizing for emotionally vulnerable children. The children caught up in the social contagion of gender ideology often have special needs they often have underlying conditions such as adhd and autism they struggle with lagging social skills obsessive rumination depression and anxiety puberty is excruciatingly hard for these emotionally intense young people and they're understandably seeking relief offered by the elusive promise of trans joy these vulnerable

[01:12:10] children often girls deserve their parents involvement as they struggle through puberty unfortunately the 2021 model policies intentionally drove a painful wedge between parents and children the psychosocial transitions espoused by the 2021 model policies cruelly put children down a one-way path into medical transitions and school staff and bureaucrats eager to oppose the 2023 policies must acknowledge the irreversible damage that so many people experience after transitioning including negative impacts on bone density cognitive development cardiovascular

[01:12:44] health fertility and sexual function the activist drafted policies from 2021 disregard these well documented risks the new 2023 model policies protect emotionally vulnerable children respect parents rights to be involved in their children's lives and free teachers from the burden of having to keep secrets from parents we appreciate the virginia department of education and governor youngkin's support for the revised policies and we hope that you all will enforce them please keep keep children safe, end secretive and destructive gender support plans, and affirm that parents have primary responsibility for their children's education and health.

[01:13:21] Susan Musket, followed by Dr. Todd Gacke. Good morning. I'm Susan Musket, president of Pro Family Women. Pro Family Women applauds Governor Youngkin's leadership in developing the 2023 model policies issued recently by the Virginia Department of Education. Governor Youngkin's model policies are a proactive step that puts parenting back into the hands of parents.

[01:13:56] The previous 2021 model policies sanctioned the dividing of children against their parents and infringed on parental rights. They even went so far as to openly instruct schools on how to keep a child's parents in the dark.

[01:14:12] When one considers the influence of the internet and peer contagion, it is alarming that the 2021 model policies issued under the Northam administration allowed students themselves to be the arbiters of their identity at school, regardless of maturity and most likely lacking full knowledge of what they were doing. Students could call the shots.

[01:14:38] They could announce their new identity without any substantiating evidence. They could choose which pronouns they wanted to be addressed by. They could enter their corresponding locker room and all without the students' parents' knowledge if the students so requested. The previous 2021 model policies went so far as to instruct school personnel that they may develop a plan whereby personnel use the student's legal name and sex-related pronouns when communicating with the student's parents, but address the student with a different name and pronouns at school.

[01:15:12] Policies which jive a wedge between a child's relationship with his or her parents causing alienation are not in the best interests of any children, much less children who are experiencing a new and rapid onset of gender dysphoria.

[01:15:29] In contrast, the new 2023 model policies protect parental rights by requiring the common-sense approach of a written instruction from a parent if a child wants to be addressed by a new name and pronoun. Counseling regarding gender dysphoria cannot take place without notifying the child's parents and giving the parents the opportunity to be involved. Pro-Family Women further appreciates that the 2023 model policies do not compel school personnel and students to address students using language that violates their constitutional rights, and that the use of locker rooms and

[01:16:08] overnight travel accommodations shall be based on biological sex, except as required by law. Governor Youngkin's 2023 model policies are a common-sense approach. They call for compassion, reasonable accommodations, protect all students, and ensure that parents are informed.

[01:16:27] thank you very much thank you dr todd gacky followed by excuse me tom and tom and torsio board and madam president members of the school board of education i'm dr todd gacky vice president of government relations for the family foundation i'm here today to speak in support of the department's finalized model policies regarding transgender issues in schools and the general principle of parental rights. Now, there's a growing list of heartbreaking examples that

[01:17:03] illustrate the dangers of policies which hide information from parents or encourage school personnel to dismiss parental rights. And I'll share three of them with you today. First is Sage from Virginia. She was the inspiration for a bill this year called Sage's Law. Sage began experimenting with gender identity and social transitioning to fit in and make friends. She then got involved with the wrong crowd and eventually lured into sex trafficking across state lines. Second is Chloe Cole. She's a teen who speaks publicly about being victimized by the gender affirming industry. At age 12, she was prescribed puberty blockers and then a double

[01:17:40] mastectomy at the age of 15. She is now a detransitioner who embraces her biological sex. And third is Yaeli Martinez. Yaeli struggled with depression, then was encouraged to social transition at school when her mom sought counseling for her the school intervened called uh caused her to be removed from

her home and placed in california foster care where she ultimately committed suicide at the age of 19. all of these cases have one thing in common they started in schools with social transitioning and we recognize there are many great educators

[01:18:15] in schools but all it takes is one person misled by an audiology or bad policies like the model 2021 version of the model policies to produce bad outcomes, to create a wedge between children and their parents and their families. And that's why the Department of Education's revised 2023 model policies and guidance are so necessary. They provide proper guidance to local schools that are parent-centered, restore and respect for parental rights and constitutional protections, prohibit schools from hiding information from parents, require counselors to notify parents

[01:18:50] about any conversations related to gender identity, and defer to family values and traditions. The model policies also comply with current Virginia state law, which says that a parent has the fundamental right to make decisions concerning the upbringing, education, and care of the parent's child. Follow Article 1, Section 11 of the Virginia Constitution, that the mere separation of the sexes shall not be considered discrimination, and adhere to a number of U.S.

[01:19:17] court decisions that affirm the rights of parents like troxel v granville prince versus massachusetts and param versus jr is our hope now that local school boards will ensure that their policies are consistent with the 20 revised 2023 model policies as required by state law thank you so much for the opportunity to speak tom and torsio followed by james anderson morning superintendent Coons, Chair Creasy, Vice Chair Hansen, and members. My name is Tom Antorcio, and I'm an

[01:19:56] Associate Director with the Virginia Catholic Conference. We believe that each person is created by God in His image and therefore has infinite value and immeasurable dignity. Our bodies are a good part, good and a part of our identity. Sexual identity is biological and God given. Parents are the first teachers of their children and have an irreplaceable role in guiding their children and ensuring their well-being. We commend Governor Yunkin and this department for issuing these updated policies, which are a considerable improvement and much-needed

[01:20:35] remediation of the former policies. The new policies enhance transparency for parents and restore their primary role in the education, care, and health of their children. They affirm and protect the dignity and safety of every student. They also respect the religious liberty and conscience rights of all members of Virginia's public school community.

[01:21:02] For those reasons, we thank the administration for these policies, and we encourage you to continue to develop those guidelines that will help make them practically implemented. Thank you.

[01:21:20] James Anderson, followed by Laura Hanford. It's good to be with you. I'm James Anderson. I've been a practicing physician for over 40 years here in Richmond, 20 years in emergency medicine, and 25 years as a clinical professor with the Department of Family Medicine at MCV.

[01:21:45] I'm here to strongly appreciate what you all have done with these model policies. Thank you for doing that. And to speak about the treatment of gender dysphoria in this world today, adolescence is hard today in today's world and if you're struggling with gender dysphoria it's almost torture all the children and adolescents need their parents and their guardians in this process it's so hard in particular with gender dysphoria the treatment of the confusion can have disastrous

[01:22:22] results in the wrong hand there are many reasons for this to allow children and adolescents to believe their words or perceptions overrule biologic reality is tantamount to allowing them to believe a lie. Age is a biologic reality. We don't allow people to state their perception of their age to determine their behavior. Age is very important in treatment modalities as well as maturity issues such as driving. Maleness and femaleness is also a biologic reality. Each one

[01:22:59] of those cells that an individual has which is up from 40 to 70 trillion cells per individual as a chromosome pair that labels that individual male or female 40 to 70 trillion cells to allow children or adolescents to determine their maleness or femaleness when their brains don't really mature until their mid-20s or early 30s is really to allow them to make lifelong decisions

[01:23:32] is inconsistent with my medical experience and need their parents involvement or guardians the treatment modalities of puberty delaying hormones or you know hormone altering gender they've never had clinical proof for them. The surgical gender-affirming procedures most medical professionals consider as mutilation. So I want to thank you for adopting policies that

[01:24:07] involve their parents and protect their children. Thank you. Laura Hanford followed by Joseph Cohn. Good morning. I'm Laura Hanford. I'm a mother of five in the Fairfax County Public Schools.

[01:24:28] I'm here to wholeheartedly support Governor Youngkin's new model policies and to say thank you because he's restored common sense to the commonwealth. These policies, these new policies, correct the critical error made by the last administration, which was removing the right of parents to be involved in their children's lives. As a longtime Fairfax County public school parent, I'm very grateful because parents are really best placed to promote their children's interests this has been true from the dawn of time in the words of marty guggenheim in the yale law review the most important way to protect children's individual interests is to maximize

[01:25:05] the authority of parents to make individualized decisions for and about them we sensibly treat children because we care and love about them and that's recognized by law but we don't need a law degree to recognize this it's just simple common sense that are shared that's shared by parents of all parties and beliefs surveys show that the great majority of virginians and americans oppose school hiding schools hiding gender transition appropriately in recognition of the diversity of virginia families the policies take no position on what decisions are made

[01:25:39] simply on who makes them children do better by every metric when parents are involved gender questioning is highly correlated to autism trauma depression anxiety body dysmorphia suicidality, complex decisions about treatment, including the use of names and pronouns, which can lock in gender dysphoria, should always include parents. And Dr. Erica Anderson, who's a transgender doctor with decades of experience and the former president of the U.S. Professional Association for Transgender Health, is firmly in support of this position. She categorically stated

[01:26:14] that transition is a major event in a youth's life and parents must be involved if that's the route that they go. Again, there's not a position taken by these policies. Debate over these gender transitions is intense and growing, and it has never been based on a formal systematic evidence review. In fact, the American Academy of Pediatrics has refused for four years to conduct such a review when every other country that has done one of these has pulled back from the American

[01:26:47] model so if kids are facing abuse that's covered in the policies schools are mandated reporters you can't have it both ways either student is in danger or they're not but based on the ideology that's not a reason to consider parents abusers by default which the north and policies did so in sum governor young can deserve our thanks for restoring to our children their true safe space which is parents thank you joseph com followed by michael carabinus

[01:27:29] good morning my name is joseph com i'm an attorney and the public policy director for family policy alliance we advocate for policies that strengthen families and religious freedom and state capitals across the country and federally we're also a proud member of the promise to america's children and parents which you heard from earlier from msup i'm here today to discuss two important ways that the 2023 model policies on ensuring privacy dignity and respect for all students and parents in virginia's public schools support and protect our children in virginia first they ensure parental involvement in children's education and second they protect the safety and privacy of our children

[01:28:05] so firstly the 2023 model policies affirm parental rights by requiring schools to allow parents to make decisions about their child's education and well-being they ensure parents are included in their child's school counseling they defer to family values taught by parents the great influence of parental involvement in a child's upbringing has been widely recognized both in this country and the state of virginia for example the u.s supreme court has repeatedly recognized the fundamental right of parents to direct the upbringing and education of their children likewise the virginia state law states that a parent has a fundamental right to make decisions concerning the upbringing education and care of the parent's child the 2023 model policies

[01:28:44] promote parental involvement on a crucial topic, so-called gender transition, and its first step, social transition. By permitting school faculty to hide children's health information from parents, the 2021 model policies risked the health and well-being of children and placed school employees in danger by encouraging them to violate parental rights. This is because social transition is increasingly being recognized as a non-neutral medical intervention. Under the 2023 model policies, parents must be notified of and consent to their child's decision to begin the gender transition process. Parents have a right and responsibility to know when their child is

[01:29:20] experiencing a mental health crisis, including an identity crisis about their sexuality. This is especially true because a mountain of evidence shows that when children are begun down the path of so-called gender transition, over 90% of them will follow through with that transition all the to its painful irreversibly damaging and sterilizing result sex change surgeries such as double mastectomies and healthy breasts parents need to be notified of changes to their children's mental health so they can get their children the help they need second the 2023 model policies vindicate the privacy rights of young girls in school bathrooms and locker rooms and they promote

[01:29:55] fairness in girls sports in contrast the 2021 model policy stripped girls of their privacy rights they allowed sex segregated activities to be separated based on a student's subjective self-identified gender identity rather than the immutable characteristic of biological sex which resulted in unfair and uncomfortable practices like allowing biological males to dominate girls sports girls have a legitimate interest in privacy and fair play especially when their biological sex is implicated this is a long-standing principle of federal law the 2023 model policies support girls by acknowledging these physical differences so in closing i urge

[01:30:29] you to support these model policies thank you for your time michael karabinos followed by sheila fury was plenty little to get here so she was skipped earlier she's here now okay as this malicious moral panic against our transgender brothers and sisters has been carefully manufactured over the past two years by media pundits religious zealots astroturf coalitions and vain politicians

[01:31:06] it has been built on a collection of often repeated lies reinforced by distorted or falsified data when confronted by lies and malice it is the duty of good citizens to speak the truth and so i and many others speak to you today the prior policy was based on the prevailing opinions of legitimate therapeutic and medical community and developed with input from the impacted community

[01:31:39] itself the new policy is based on the same malicious lies i've already alluded to the prior policy recognized that 40 of homeless youth are members of the queer community and that family conflict is the prevailing cause of that homelessness the new policy would forcibly force children to be exposed who are not ready or afraid to come out to their parents because many fear that exact fate. The old policy recognized that over 50% of trans youth contemplate suicide

[01:32:18] and that number is decreased by gender affirming care. The new policy would deny or sabotage key pieces of that care and social transition. The result of this policy will be homeless and dead children. And the message of this policy is that this administration would prefer dead kids to trans kids. Look, I'm a parent, and as such, I have responsibilities that come with my rights.

[01:32:56] If my kid is afraid to talk to me about who they are, it means I have failed and done a pretty poor job as a parent. I hear folks talk about parents' rights a lot, but that does not include a right to ownership. Our children are human beings with human emotions, wants, needs, and rights of their own no one can make someone gay no one can make someone trans but gay and trans people know they are from a very early age even before they have the language or the safety to express that and

[01:33:35] all this policy does is deny that safety there's no such thing as transgender ideology there is only transgender identity and you cannot eradicate an identity thank you sir the god i believe it is god of love sheila fury followed by sunflower collective morning i'm dr sheila fury i'm a child

[01:34:10] and adolescent psychiatrist and i specialize in learning disabilities and i am very sad because the commonwealth has spent hundreds if not thousands of hours in time and money on sex on sex buying books educating our children in health and their health classes and it's not

[01:34:49] fundamental biology about sex it's about gender identity it's about who you're going to have sex with and how you're going to have sex and what disturbs me is that every time i have been at these meetings i have heard the anguished pleas of parents who want their child who is learning disabled to receive fundamental cognitive education. Fundamental cognitive education.

[01:35:26] It disturbs me that month after month, they plead with you to get services for their children. And as a psychiatrist who specializes in children with learning disabilities, years ago i completely gave up on the system that is sad i had to educate my two children who have

[01:36:02] dyslexia outside the system and yet you are spending here in the governor and this committee and i respect all the time and effort you have put into this and the gender policies but your fundamental role is to provide cognitive education for the student, not sex education to the students.

[01:36:33] And though this policy is a step in the right direction, I am very concerned because the law, state and federal, allows the parent to identify their child as transgendered and use the bathroom of their choice parents need to be aware that they need to opt out they need to opt out and they need to be critically informed if their child is going to be exposed thank you thank you for your time

[01:37:12] sunflower collective followed by michelle please pardon my pronunciation erinheim sunflower collective followed by Dr. Michelle Ehrenheim. I'm Dr. Ehrenheim. Good morning. My name is Dr.

[01:37:41] Michelle Ehrenheim. I'm a board-certified family physician with over 25 years of clinical experience working with children and their parents in Northern Virginia. I'm also a parent of two middle school students i am here to speak in support of the new 2023 model policies on ensuring privacy dignity and respect for all students and parents in virginia's public schools multiple medical studies have shown that parental involvement in a child's education is positively

[01:38:16] associated with the child's academic performance over and above the impact of the child's intelligence children of involved parents have better peer interactions and more advanced social skills than those students with uninvolved parents studies also show a decrease in school truancy substance abuse delinquent acts and improved mental health in children whose parents are engaged with their education over the past several years i have seen an increase in children with gender

[01:38:50] dysphoria they often have associated anxiety depression and academic difficulties as a physician caring for these children i find that those with strong parental engagement show better clinical improvement with treatment interventions parents are the best advocates and protectors of their children and they should be leading the conversations and decisions about their child's identity given the increase in children identifying as non-binary and transgender

[01:39:26] i support the availability of single user bathrooms and facilities in schools that can be accessible to all students to promote each child's privacy and safety several medical studies including a recent one in the british journal of sports medicine has found that transgender women have physical advantages in strength and heart and lung capacity over biological women in the same age group. As a mother of a middle school female athlete, I strongly support the policy that participation of students in athletic programs should be

[01:40:04] determined by sex instead of gender or gender identity. In conclusion, I thank the team at the Virginia Board of Education for putting policies into place to protect the privacy and safety of all students and to empower parents as the primary educators of their students with the right to direct their academic physical and mental well-being without secrets from or

[01:40:30] interference by school employees thank you hannah huddle followed by phil low is hannah huddle here

[01:40:45] phil low okay gerald binkley followed by charles waddell good morning and congratulations to all of you have enjoyed a new job this year today you constitute a new board and a new mission

[01:41:22] my name is Cheryl Gibbs Binkley I come as a 20-year teacher of high schoolers college students and student teachers and since everybody is trotting out their religious credentials this morning I also have a reverend diploma from a seminary and I'm the author of Jesus and his kingdom of equals the children's materials for the Jesus Seminar, the preeminent thinking on the historical Jesus globally.

[01:41:56] In those 20 years of teaching, I lost two young people to suicide, one a student and one a close family friend of my children and myself. They were both beautiful and both endured bullying and rejection as they struggled with their gender identity.

[01:42:19] I'm here today to honor their attempts to live even though they lost that battle. One of the critical tasks of parents and children across adolescence is for children to gain responsible self-management and parents to gradually let go as their children do gain that.

[01:42:41] It parallels toddlerhood and potty training as one of the more fraught times of parenting, as anybody who's had a teenage child will tell you. middle and high school teachers are often called on to be the benevolent and caring friends of that process every day as a teacher i taught many children with great parents that i worked with closely and joyfully i taught students with struggling broken and angry parents sometimes

[01:43:16] more angry with one another than anyone else in the world who all needed the compassion and support that we could gather for them and i taught some with no parents at all it is only by deeply valuing the humanity of each of those children that we can help them become their whole and most magnificent selves which is our mission i've read the model policies of this department and

[01:43:50] administration has put forward i'm here to ask you not to adopt those policies that are more like a manifesto of parental authoritarianism than a healthy way to support students and their parents and they lack all common sense don't let them tell you it is common sense thank you charles waddell followed by stephanie worked excuse me president creasy vice president hanson

[01:44:28] members of the board members of the board staff parents fellow citizens i'm charlie waddell i live in the historic hanover historic henry district of hanover county i'm a retired computer consultant and i now self-identify as a substitute teacher in the hanover county school systems an experience which has caused me to rue my misspent adulthood i've done a review of your model policies the 2023 in short i wish to thank you for your efforts to address issues that have arisen from a small number of students and which distract from the basic goal of any educational

[01:45:06] school system and that being to provide a quality education educational experience for all students i appreciate that your policy acknowledges parental rights in making decisions for raising and educating their children and current involvement in the children's education the 2021 model policy shamefully disregarded the rights of parents but as your policy so aptly states empowering parents is not only a fundamental right but also essential to improving outcomes for all children in virginia

[01:45:42] that old policy deserves to be discarded because it excuse me sinus problems because it willfully discarded disregarded one basic principle that families play an important role in helping youth succeed in high school and beyond i owe my parents a debt that i can never repay for their support and guidance my stepfather fought the battle at late gulf which is the navy version of or is tantamount to the normandy invasion his example guided me in life your policy is sound and fair

[01:46:21] under section 2 guiding principles school shall respect all students parents have the right to make decisions with respect to their children a basic tenant of any policy children shall respect parents values and benefits your policy is replete with united states constitutional virginia constitutional state and federal legislative authority that defines and outlines the freedoms and protections of the rights of the parents as well as the students additionally

[01:46:55] your policy mandates actions for the protection of the students i have seen firsthand um discipline invoked in the schools it works it protects the students thank you for respect and effectiveness and for promulgating a well-seasoned policy thank you very much stephanie worked followed by aaron saint germain good morning i'm stephanie worked and i've been teaching in a public high

[01:47:30] school in rural virginia for the last 24 years and i'm the very proud parent of a transgender student who came through those public schools and is now thriving at vcu i'm here to speak out against these new model policies related to transgender students i am thankful that in powhatan teachers my son had coming through school supported him in using his chosen name and pronoun even when his father did not agree he didn't have support at home we had two split homes we know that the

[01:48:09] support of a parent the influence of a parent is prime necessary support for every child but what about these kids who don't get that support at home where is their safe space where are they accepted and acknowledged for their individuality school's what they've got this policy is detrimental to that if my son's teachers were required to continue to dead name him he would have spiraled further into that depression of not a cause by not being accepted at home he struggled

[01:48:49] for that acceptance thank god he didn't have to struggle so much at school i've seen the damage done to kids whose parents don't support them in 24 years of teaching high school i've seen a lot i've seen kids who question who they are and what they think because what they think is true is different from what their parents tell them is true that's a hard thing for a kid to struggle all right kids look up to their parents for guidance they look to their teachers for guidance

[01:49:23] and acceptance and if they get that nowhere it is very detrimental this policy requires teachers to out students before they may be ready this policy requires teachers to dead name students if they don't have written consent from the parents to use their chosen name well what do we do if one parent says yes i support my child using that name and one parent says oh no i don't support that what do you do then as a teacher what i do is i listen to the child in front of me as a public school

[01:50:03] educator it is my job to educate the kids sitting in front of me i'm not educating their parents i'm not educating politicians i'm not educating religious leaders i am educating the youth in front of me i am educating the leaders of tomorrow all right i am not refusing to identify them as who they are teachers need the support and ability to support our kids thank you aaron saint germain

[01:50:40] followed by eric sunberg good morning my name is aaron saint germain i am a mother a parent from fairfax county and i am here to um support governor youngkin's 2023 model policies um we've heard a lot today about what the law says what um what the bible says what common sense says what doctors say but what we haven't heard is what the research says about parent involvement with their transgender

[01:51:17] children. I looked in the literature, I looked in public data, and research does show that transgender individuals are more likely to attempt suicide, experience violence, become homeless, and victims of sex trafficking. Research does not show that parental abuse or neglect causes any of that not a single study there's no data in the scientific literature there's no data at the state level there's no data at the local level there's no data from cps or um custodies that show that children are being accused and neglected transgender children are being abused

[01:51:55] and neglected at the hands of their parents because of their gender identity and activists frequently cite faulty studies that combine running away with being kicked out and those are very different especially when you consider the mental health issues that transgender youth frequently very often experience so that is something that needs to be explored so there's no basis for the argument that schools need to implement policies to protect children from their own parents in fact

[01:52:30] the largest survey of transgender individuals from trans equality.org found that only 18% of transgender people reported their parents not supporting their gender identity. 77% reported being bullied, harassed at school. So this notion that the school is the place that's going to save these kids has no basis. So I just want to again thank Governor Youngkins and the board for

[01:53:02] adopting the 2023 policies backed in data and science and confirming parental support thank you eric sundberg followed by jimanna al-mohim is eric sundberg here okay how about jimanna

[01:53:26] al-mohim bo baloti is bo baloti here kelly singer brennan mcquillen dr scott armistead hi i'm scott

[01:54:03] armistead and i'm a family doctor here in richmond and i work with medical students teaching and mentoring and then also work in care of the underserved and of refugees thank you for loving the students of virginia and thank you for telling them that you do so i've come today as a citizen a parent of three sons and a medical doctor in support of the revised 2023 policies of the board i come having been raised in hanover county educated william and mary medical college of Virginia and then having practiced medicine since 1994 both in the state of Virginia and then for 16

[01:54:38] years in a village in northern Pakistan so I have these two cultures swimming around in my head Virginian and South Asian and I very much identify with them both giving me an appreciation particularly for growing immigrant and refugee populations in Virginia and the quite different and more conservative perspectives they often have toward things such as parenting gender and what it means to be an embodied human being. So I support this policy change because while acknowledging the reality of gender dysphoria and the need for deep compassion and respect

[01:55:13] and understanding in dealing with children with gender dysphoria, it also affirms the central role and authority of parents in making decisions about the education of their children and a role clearly written in our American history and across cultures and reflected in our legal system.

[01:55:30] i also support this policy because it affirms the centrality of a respect for the givenness of the body the gendered body of all students because i think it's the confusion about the meaning of the gendered body and the increasing disrespect of the body in our culture and in some of our medical systems that concerns me the most the normalization of an understanding that the body is extrinsic not intrinsic to the human lowers the status of the body to the extent that the body becomes something

[01:56:03] just to be technologically manipulated. In fact, many Virginians like me believe that the gendered body is intrinsic, not extrinsic to the human. It's a beautiful gift to be received and not a shell to be rejected and to be modified. The normalization of the confused anthropology is unhealthy for our civilization, and the suppression of voices like mine and others who have resisted the confusion in our academic institutions and otherwise is very concerning to me. What this legislation

[01:56:37] acknowledges is that the forced accommodation in language, which reflects this confused anthropology and ideology, is unwise and not becoming of our commonwealth. So I applaud the board for

these policy changes and believe they're in the best interest of Virginia's families and Virginia's children. And I applaud the central place parents are given. And I applaud the affirmation of an understanding of the gender body as a respected given in our culture. Thank

[01:57:05] you. Ann McLean, followed by Alan Danakis. Is Ann McLean here? Okay. Alan Danakis. Alan Danakis now.

[01:57:26] Wendy Little. Greetings, new board members. Greetings, fellow scholars. Greetings, media.

[01:58:03] Everyone else, Dr. Coons. My name is Wendy Little. My name is Wendy Little. This is my son, Aaron Little. He has three state complaint violations by Chesterfield County Schools, the last one being violation of FAPE the entire 22-23 school year.

[01:58:26] This is what special education is like in Virginia. A faucet. My son had no education last year. None. We need to stop denying the rights and needs of special education students and appropriately fund them.

[01:58:48] Desterfield County. Desterfield County made my son the poster child. They made him sit in filth. He has a condition, a bowel leakage condition. No matter what I filled in, no matter what I sent in, doctor's notes, everything, they denied him medical health aid. I have been trying to get an investigation with the attorney general for over a year. Last month, I provided a letter from Winston Sears from last year. I have with me today. Where's all that stuff in the meeting minutes?

[01:59:19] Where is it? I didn't hear from anyone. You know, I have it again. I also have a letter to Miara's office requesting an investigation. How does a school division get away with allowing a son to sit, a child with disabilities, to sit in bowel leakage year after year, despite all the appropriate medical documents, despite requested letters of medical need, and then deny him an educational year?

[01:59:44] This is why you've seen my name, Dr. Coons. A school division in Virginia should not be treating children like this for a period of five years. And it's not only my son, it's so many others that come all the time, whether there's something politically hot going on or whether there's not.

[02:00:04] There's one constant, and it's always someone speaking up for the special needs kids who have been neglected and left behind, and nobody will do anything. It's time for that to stop. Now, I do request that you invoke Virginia Ed 22.1-214E on Chesterfield County Public Schools.

[02:00:26] There are three legitimate federal complaint violations on my son alone within one year. It is time to take action. And while you may have a better plan moving forward, we've got to take care of the kids who've been abused and neglected now.

[02:00:43] And we need your help to do something because y'all are killing us and killing our kids by letting this go on and people are lying to you and not giving you all the information we need your help and we need our voices heard thank you thank you at this time we would invite anyone else who is in the audience who did not sign up but would like to speak please make sure

[02:01:16] that you state your name and what organization you may be a part of my name is Katrina Van Orden I am a child of Fairfax County Public School System and now a current resident of Richmond city. I've never lived anywhere but Virginia, and I intend to stay and raise children in this state. I'm addressing the 2023 model policies. These policies are explicitly and implicitly harmful to trans, non-binary, and

queer students. I was a queer student in high school with parents who, on the surface, seemed to really care about my best interests. They

[02:01:54] were engaged with my teachers. They cared about my education. I got really good grades. But at home, they were controlling, they were abusive, and they were homophobic. But no one would know that from outside the home. The teachers had no clue. So I would not have fallen under that abuse exemption that the model policies now have. Under these policies, I would have been stripped of my only safe space, and there is a high possibility that I would not be here today.

[02:02:22] None of the supporters of these new model policies have experienced what us queer folks have experienced. They cannot speak to this topic with any nuance, firsthand knowledge, or compassion because of that you notice none of them talked about their own personal experiences being students facing this type of situation schools should be a safe space for all children to express themselves and to experience all that the public schools have to offer this includes being respected in their classrooms this includes participating in sports and this includes safely navigating

[02:02:57] adolescence these model policies will not protect virginia students shame on the department of education, shame on Glenn Youngkin. We just want these students to graduate alive. That's what we care about. Is there anyone else who wishes to speak at this time? My name is Radian. I'm a transgender kid that graduated in the class of 2020 from Henrico County Public Schools. And I just

[02:03:35] want to say, first off, thank you all for giving me your time. It's an honor to speak in front of right now um there are a lot of people who say things like parents are given um affirmation to raise their children the way they like and of course there is that no one's stopping them from raising their kids however they like but i don't hear a lot of people talk about kids like me that grew up in a home where i was told that um i was dragged to church every sunday i was told that

[02:04:13] um as long as i would you know confess all of my sins and bring myself in front of god that i would be forgiven and he would have a place for me in heaven um however at the same time i grew up in a household where they told me i could be whatever i wanted to be as long as i wasn't gay or trans and for a really long time i wondered why i spent the night before prom crying in bed wondering what's wrong with me why can't i just wear this dress that my mom bought for me

[02:04:46] that she that i love the stress that she gave me and i can't do it sorry policies like 2023 model policies that i know that you all are aware of at this point um it it sounds great for parents but kids like me whose parents don't qualify as abusive because they aren't getting hit or i don't know aren't being told that they can't live here anymore if they're gay my parents tiptoed

[02:05:21] around it so they could do anything that wouldn't be looked upon as abuse um school was the only only place that I had. I had teachers and administrators ask me what my, what name I wanted to be called and what pronouns I wanted to go by. And it was pretty much my lifeline getting through high school. I think all of these people are here for certainly reasons for their own accord. And I don't doubt that no one here, I think that everyone here definitely

[02:05:56] cares about children. I just think that maybe sometimes you have to put it in the hands of a child, you know, no one's going to be able to advocate for kids like me, who were not able to really speak up for themselves until after they were out of the education system. I just think that I really want to urge everyone here to really think about the model policies and think about

[02:06:25] what that looks like for kids like me. Thank you. Is there anybody else who wishes to speak? Okay, Seeing none, we will close the public comment section of this meeting, and we will take a 10-minute break.

[02:22:17] So item A is, or well, actually, the board typically approves the consent agenda as a block, and we've already moved item C to discussion items. So can I have a motion to approve items A and B on the agenda, please?

[02:22:35] Move. Second. The motion has been moved and seconded. Please indicate by saying aye if you approve. Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye.

[02:23:01] President votes aye. Okay. All right. Moving on to our action items. Mr. Chapman is going to be helping us out with item C, first and final review of divisions partnering with ITEACH to provide an alternate route to licensure. So I know there's going to be discussion on this, but to follow our procedure, I'd like to have a motion on this item in order to open up discussion. Is there a motion for to waive first review and approve petitions for alternate route for three years in accordance

[02:23:36] with the guidelines with conditions on the superintendent's recommendation so moved second okay mr chapman would you like to jump in here thank you president precy vice president hansen members of the board and dr coons i know you've all seen an item that looked almost exactly like this uh in the june meeting so i'm not going to go over those points of the presentation i would just like to note that in the time since uh this uh this item went live and this is revised not only

[02:24:11] in your um your packet but also on the sharepoint and also on the website we've received a couple of other applications and so we would ask that as part of this item that the board would also consider the applications from campbell county public schools madison county public schools north hampton county public schools which have been received in that time this is a popular item and And so I'll just also note that with the superintendent's recommendation, the department is requesting that the board direct the department to go ahead and approve substantially similar applications.

[02:24:45] We know that with the teacher shortage, this is something that counties would like and school divisions would like to make sure that teachers, they're getting teachers, you know, through their pipeline and getting this started. And so we would love it if this happened more expeditiously on the administrative side. Thank you.

[02:25:01] Is there any discussion on this idea? yes if i may uh miss folton thank you madam president uh as to the uh the last matter that mr chapman mentioned the suggestion that we defer authority to the superintendent for future ones i'd just like to make sure that we check that we have the legal authority to do that under the guidelines i don't know whether guidelines and regulations allow us to defer that authority so perhaps that's something we can be checking on while we discuss other matters um and i as

[02:25:36] to other matters i'd just like to uh raise and can repeat for the oag yeah uh there's a suggestion there's a request that we defer to the superintendent the authority to grant future applications similar to the ones in item c today and my question is does the statute and our guidelines allow us to grant that to to delegate that authority to the superintendent mr shatman and and just to be clear we're not asking that the board defer its authority but that it direct the department to only approve substantially similar items with iTeach and we we have received

[02:26:15] guidance from oag just about the uh the administrative nature of these and that the board should act and strive in all instances to act identically in identical situations so it's very very narrow the oag has weighed in that we do have the authority to delegate that we do have the capacity to delegate that authority to the superintendent okay thank you uh so moving on to my my next issue i i it has come to my attention that um we do not have the necessary information with respect to one portion of these applications only and that is the application as with respect

[02:26:53] to special ed teachers uh for all the other uh endorsements i we are we have been shown that the iTeach program we've been shown a matrix showing how it corresponds to the regulatory requirements we've been shown the syllabuses for the court the syllabi for the courses that iTeach has offers to meet those requirements but that documentation is missing as to special ed and given the importance of these licenses i would like to suggest that we do what really is normal which is to accept

[02:27:29] this matter on first review today uh we the normal process is first review one meeting final review the next being it gives the public the opportunity to have input here it will give us the opportunity to hear from i teach as to those gaps in the record and also to hear from staff and frankly i understand that our special ed and licensure staff that we don't have the right people here today summer vacations etc um but uh i would want to hear from them in september as we did back in april hear from them as to the other endorsements but not to the special ed endorsement as to how

[02:28:07] i teach is going to be meeting this requirement and i would just say uh you know we all recognize how urgently we need more teachers and that's one of the reasons we're excited to support the I teach application and I am too and in particular how desperately we need special ed teachers and how many it's it's a very large growing population of special ed provisional licensees but we also know that provisional licensees particularly in special ed who don't get the the support they need don't last and don't our retention rates are extremely low the gaps that I've seen particularly

[02:28:47] and I'm happy to go through the record if you like, but are particularly with the severe and profound disabilities kids, the courses that I teach says it's going to offer on those. We have the syllabi for the other courses, and then we get to those courses, and it says in development. They're just not there. They weren't there back in April. I've asked the department to ask I teach to supply them to us, and I teach sent some additional documentation in,

[02:29:15] but it still doesn't contain the syllabi for the two most important courses, arguably, in the special ed curriculum, and that one of them being the one that addresses kids with significant disabilities. We don't have anything showing how I teach is going to meet the requirements that our special ed teachers be taught about the medical conditions that underlie some of those severe and profound disabilities, and how adaptations in the provision of education to those children meet those disabilities.

[02:29:50] And the documentation that I teach did submit some additional documentation that came in yesterday, and I was reading it in our gaps, or maybe it came in Tuesday. It's full of errors and omissions. They've got, even for the course numbers that they've assigned to the courses that quote in development are listed one way someplace and another way another place so it's a bit of a mess and I would want us to hear more from iTeach before we approve these these crucially important

[02:30:24] educational component for our special ed teachers and and I would want to hear from staff as we did with the other endorsements that they've gone through the regulations and give us a matrix as they did back in April with respect to the other endorsements showing how the syllabi match up to the matrices

to the regulatory requirements. We can't waive our regulatory requirements by approving this. So somehow IT has got to teach this material and I'm sure they're working to do that and it would certainly be my hope that they can come back to us in September which would be

[02:31:02] the normal course for when this matter is, or whenever we next meet, when this matter next comes before us, that we can then approve these applications. But with the gaps in our knowledge, I think it would be hasty to approve it on final review today. Mr. Rotherham?

[02:31:20] Ms. Alden, I just want to make sure I understand. So are you objecting to approving around special ed or objecting to moving a slate of districts? That's one. Obviously, you'll offer some sort of substitute i'm trying to figure out what it will be and then second they've sent us the stuff that like is how they meet these standards but you want to see the actual syllabi those are just just clarifying questions which i understand your position so on the first point uh i i i'm open to an alternative motion if it be the will of the board at this point my my my vote would be and

[02:31:58] i would urge our colleagues to vote no consistent with our normal process that we don't accept matters on first we don't do final votes on first review so if we deny the motion today then the matter would kick over to final review at the next meeting so i think that would be the procedural stance if folks want to uh if if the board is amenable i'd be happy to offer us an amendment that the um that we approve on first and final review the applications as to the endorsements

[02:32:33] other than special ed that's okay thank you um and and with respect to because i do think we have the documentation with respect to the special ed i'm sorry just as to your second point with respect to the special ed we do not have uh the what they've given us doesn't show us what they they claim it shows us number one number two it's not what we had for all the other endorsements where we had not just the syllabi but we had the staff doing the matrix crosswalk and and you know this is uh something that we really should benefit from our staff

[02:33:08] expertise just because they're on vacation today doesn't mean we shouldn't get benefit of their yeah that's i understand now and i i think it's important we don't treat these divisions with regard to stuff we already approved last month we don't treat them different just because they are on this if i may speak to that this these gaps do apply to what we did last june too and frankly you know what what should have happened is we should have been alerted to these gaps back when we heard this matter in may and that was before the current administration and lots of the current personnel were in place and how how how exactly that happened back in april is um

[02:33:47] something i'm not trying to uh figure out like i'm just trying to move forward but my sense would be if we can with respect to these new applications get confidence that i teach is adequately teaching these special ed courses, then that will solve the problem with respect to all the ones we voted on in June as well. And that's the right solution. I will say that it's my understanding that I teach when they offer special ed endorsements or their equivalent in other states,

[02:34:23] it is paired with a special ed praxis requirement, which we don't have here in Virginia. So we don't have the assurance of a praxis that these teachers are getting this content knowledge, but the fact that iTeach is apparently helping teachers learn this content and pass the praxis for special ed in other states makes me think that iTeach must have the content, you know, they should be able to get us this documentation. It shouldn't be that hard for them to be able to show us what it is they're teaching to teachers in other states that's helping those teachers pass

[02:34:59] the cracks Dr. Siebert a question for staff um Jim plus or minus five ballpark how many divisions applications were approved last month 24 oh exactly very precise okay 24 and uh the total number today with the ones we just added I believe that'd be six six um that then leads me to kind of sorry that's way low nine nine that kind of brings me to my my thought on this and sort of sort of a metaphor i want to thank uh my colleague ms holton for this is kind of like uh you're wearing a

[02:35:38] construction zone this is something we're still building and like when you enter a construction zone highway you got to slow down so i appreciate the opportunity to slow down here and talk about this and think about it um but my my concern is the pace of the school year the fact that we already have 24 approved we have others available today i i don't i don't i think you should slow down a work zone i i don't want to bring them to a stop um i'd like to see them continue to move and work forward but i think this shines a pretty bright light on an area of of need um so i feel pretty confident the staff and and the the vendor will continue to build out these two areas i think now divisions who approved last month and those that we may approve this month would be very

[02:36:17] attentive to this because again especially this case this is hugely hugely important but i also like to say i think there's a backstop a safety net here and i think that safety net are the local divisions because the local school divisions will be using uh the the commonwealth teacher evaluation system to process with establishing professional goals and objectives evaluating effectiveness in in the classroom giving feedback and coaching and i absolutely agree that the feedback piece we're going to keep building out the kind of coaching support we give to new and and less experienced teachers so i i yes i think the special ed piece probably probably in my

[02:36:52] opinion special ed piece front needs to be built out more we need more it needs to be more robust um i think there should be a pretty urgent directive that they give us peace of mind about that our next meeting but i i do when we have 24 divisions kind of like running i don't want to tell these new ones that they cannot um because i do think there's a safety net there i i trust our local divisions to give the feedback and support that they need madam president mr Certifan? With the 33 divisions that have done their research and came before us and gave us

[02:37:29] packets saying, we want this, we want this. My role is to support them. One of the main points they made was that they're going to give additional tools to their staff and help their staff get to a point where they're going to be very effective. But their stumbling block is the certification.

[02:37:49] We know that this program can expedite that process. And that is why I believe so many school divisions. So many HRs, so many superintendents are pushing for this. And as our board, I don't think we should get in that way. I think we should vote as it stands without removing any portion so that we can give them the tools they need for success. As Alan has said, it's construction.

[02:38:15] What happens when you stop construction? Bad things. Once construction starts, you have to keep on going. And there are always going to be some things you may have to do to tweak it a little bit, but to pull it out now, I look at it as a package that these many school divisions have asked for. And I've said in the last meeting, I want to fully support them and give them their tools. Any other discussion, Dr. Northern? So, you know, we got this yesterday, which, you know, I wish we'd gotten it sooner. I understand, you know, this is my first meeting. I don't know the

[02:38:52] history, like most of you know, around the table. But my first thing is to go to the standards, because I want to know what's in these things and what they look like and what the content is. I see

something I like and something I don't like. So, for instance, on the TVCA 5400 course, they're talking about applying differentiated instructional methods, learning cognitive strategies.

[02:39:18] I love that. We've seen some concern here that there's not enough emphasis on cognitive strategies for students with special needs. That's a good thing. Diverse learning styles. That's been completely debunked. You know, there's a lot of research on diverse learning styles that show that it's just has no research merit.

[02:39:39] So I would support us continuing to give feedback on these and have our divisions give feedback on these because I think they can be strengthened. But I also agree with my colleagues that, you know, this would probably hamstring some of our districts who are desperately in need of help in the special education domain.

[02:40:00] So I think we need to collaborate with the districts, get feedback from them, and get feedback from other experts. But I don't think we should stop in the middle of the construction zone and halt. I'm sorry, Mr. Rotherham. Go ahead, Mr. Rotherham.

[02:40:19] I think it might be useful just for the public, and maybe this is you, Doc. Can someone describe, so if a candidate is pursuing special ed through iTeach right now, what will that experience actually look like for them? We're not prepared to speak on that today, Mr. Rotherham.

[02:40:36] but because the staff isn't here and because the documents don't show it madam president no because i teach is not here to describe that with their school divisions but i'm happy to get that information to you i just don't i was not prepared to answer that question happy to get it for you okay mr certifan do we ever ask all the additional programs what it's like what's the process all the other educational institutions each one is different if i may respond to that yes we do

[02:41:06] Ms. Holtan? I'm sorry. Ms. Holtan? I'm sorry. He thought it was. Are you, were you done? I didn't mean to cut you off. Yes, we do. We have staff for all of our alternative programs. We have the staff review how the proposals match up to our regulatory requirements. And what we have here, our guidelines require us to find that the alternative programs meet the regulatory requirements.

[02:41:32] And, you know, we have here where there was a gap in the record that wasn't brought to our attention for reasons that aren't clear back in April. But now it has been brought to our attention. I'm bringing it to, I was brought to my attention and I'm bringing it to your attention that we don't have the documentation. So yes, we don't want to slow things down. We aren't slowing things down. The norm is first and final review that gives the divisions. I teach staff, others a chance to come show us.

[02:41:59] And it's certainly my hope that they've got the blueprint for how to move forward and that we're going to be able to make sure it all goes forward for all the divisions well. But we are not getting in the way. We're just trying to help them get it right. And right now, you know, the requirements, the two of the four courses that I teach proposes to offer to our special ed teachers, there is complete absence of record that says they are in development.

[02:42:30] It said that back in April. And when I asked for it again last week, it still says that. So there must be something there if they've and if absent that we don't have any assurance that the regulatory requirements are going to be met. And therefore, our guidelines do not, in my reading, allow us to approve this, these alternative proposals today.

[02:42:55] Dr. Cans? Syllabus has happened. Syllabi have been received this morning. Well, that's great that they've been received this morning. I'd love to see them and love to have the staff's evaluation as we had with all the other endorsements that they meet the requirements. But, you know, something that was received this morning doesn't help me in my deliberation today.

[02:43:14] All the better reason to put it off. We're going to meet. We're talking about meeting for a special meeting in August. Maybe it doesn't have to be a long period at all. I won't belabor the point. I won't repeat myself. would present the alternative uh um amendment motion if there was interest in it um at this point we have a motion made and seconded um what i would like to do at this point is uh call the question and move on and and uh ask for a roll call vote on this so we are um the motion on the

[02:43:53] table uh is that we would waive first review and approve the petitions for alternate route for three years in accordance with the guidelines with the condition in the superintendent's recommendation miss kilgore how do you vote miss holton no dr siebert hi mr hanson dr northern mr sturdifant hi mr rotherham no chair votes aye for the record i'd be prepared to move it on first review but i do think there's enough questions here uh do we need to pause

[02:44:31] and the motion passes. Thank you. Now we are moving to first and final review of the recommendation regarding the literacy fund loan applications for approval and release of funds. Is there a motion to waive first review and approve the release of literacy fund loan to Franklin County in the amount of $25 million for the Benjamin Franklin Middle School renovation project and an annual interest rate of 3% payable over 20 years.

[02:45:05] We'll move. Second. Any discussion? Mr. Dickey is here to help us if we need his amazing assistance. May I ask this question for Mr. Dickey? Mr. Dickey, is this the matter that there was a speaker this morning who asked that we, from the Virginia School Board Association, I think, who asked that we accept this solely on first review, not final review today was that a different agenda item no he wasn't here for that speaker so I'm

[02:45:40] happy that was on the um School Construction Grants this is on the Literary Loan Fund thank you yeah withdraw my question any questions for Mr Dickey or any discussion by board members okay so the motion on the table has been made and seconded to to waive first review and approve the release of literacy fund loan to Franklin County in the amount of $25 million for the Benjamin Franklin Middle School Renovation Project at an annual interest rate of 3% payable over 20 years. Ms.

[02:46:18] Kilgore, how do you vote? Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Mr. Hanson? Aye. Okay.

[02:46:36] Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. And Chair votes aye. Motion passes. you mr you're on our next one right yes thanks madam president good morning uh board members dr coons uh item uh e is uh first and final review of requests for guidance on the school construction assistance program and consideration of program changes for this um major new uh competitive grant program for school construction and renovation and just very quickly by way of

[02:47:09] background um 450 million in funding um as you know was provided for the program in the current state budget um the appropriation act language also um required the board to develop guidelines for the program that that was completed uh in the winter time frame um the key requirement in those

guidelines were the competitive criteria uh relating to uh poor building conditions commitment need uh and your your guidelines um uh include uh 11 scoring criteria and associated

[02:47:47] point values and those are shown in attachment a and those are the critical um criteria and and uh point values uh that are that are used for uh awarding grants under this competitive program that the language also required you to um adopt a minimum qualifying score on the scoring criteria that was done in the guidelines and applied to the first round of applications at 65 points, so school applications must score a minimum of 65 points on a 100-point scale to be considered for

[02:48:23] funding, and that was used to run the first application process last winter, and you ultimately approved um uh 40 school pro awards for 40 school projects and 28 divisions uh at your special meeting in may for a total of 365 million in grant funds also at the may board meeting you asked staff to conduct a 30-day data review process and school divisions were allowed

[02:48:57] to request a review of their scoring data uh for that initial round of applications uh for any data errors or incorrect scoring that that review's been completed by staff and and no um data quality or scoring issues were identified uh through that review process so that has been uh completed as as requested and then at this point uh in the in the program as we've gone through one application round uh 365 million in grant awards were uh awarded uh those are uh beginning to be

[02:49:33] implemented with the awarding school divisions there's approximately 85 million in grant funding that remains available uh for award um this this year uh and but before moving forward uh doe uh is seeking guidance from the board on any changes to the program it desires to make before we move forward with any additional rounds of application or award of funding of course some some changes may require revisions to the guidelines before proceeding proceeding with

[02:50:07] another application process and staff is requesting the board to help provide direction on next steps with the remaining funds on page two of the agenda item or some is a non-exhaustive list of possible options to consider at this point in time number one would be the status quo and proceed with another open application process for school divisions to apply with no change

[02:50:42] to the program guidelines or scoring criteria. Secondly, review previously submitted grant applications from the first round that were not funded due to the point total, not scoring 65 points, but review those applications based on a reduced minimum scoring total of 60 points, which would be a reduction of five points from the current guidelines.

[02:51:10] A third option, more expansive, is open another round of applications with a reduced minimum scoring criteria, for instance, 60 points, or revise individual scoring criteria in the guidelines, either the point system or the content of the 11 criteria themselves.

[02:51:36] And then lastly, other changes is recommended during discussion. All of this would then lead to the timeline to open new rounds of applications. We have received multiple inquiries from school divisions on the next timeline for the next round of applications and when the department will proceed with the next round of applications.

[02:52:04] And Madam President, very quickly, House Appropriations staff also provided input on the last several days on the program that they asked to be shared with the board. Very briefly, three points that staff there sent to us, a recommendation for a fixed application period each year versus a rolling open application period.

[02:52:33] That would allow some predictability and timeline for school divisions to prepare for grant applications, particularly for lower resource school divisions that don't frequently do capital projects, but they would know the point in the year in which the application timeline is going to open if there's available funding in the fund.

[02:52:57] in terms of remaining funds, their input is to maintain the existing program cut scores at 65 points, presumably also maintain the current 11 scoring criteria. And then they've encouraged the board and the department to post to the town hall for public comment, any future changes to the guidelines. That was not done initially because it was deemed, the guidelines for this program were deemed to be exempted under the APA because they are implementing guidelines for a

[02:53:36] state funded grant program, which are exempted from the code requirements for public comment. So those were three areas of feedback and input from house appropriations.

[02:53:53] Madam President, the superintendent recommends that the board consider the various options previously outlined for changing the program and provide guidance to DOE staff on proceeding moving forward. Thank you.

[02:54:10] Mr. Dickey, before we make a motion here, can you remind me what has been spent in this fund and then what is left to be spent? Yeah, at the May board meeting, the board awarded $365 million. We are on the cusp of receiving some of the first reimbursement requests for some of the first projects that are rolling out. We will be receiving those very soon. In fact, well, we've actually received one on an unawarded basis.

[02:54:40] There's $84.7 million left from the original $450 million general fund and literary fund appropriation that kicked off the program from the General Assembly. Of course, the casino revenues, which are slowly building, are partly dedicated to this fund as well.

[02:55:02] That's in the early stages of that revenue generation. So we're essentially, from this initial round or two, working off of the initial $450 million appropriation from the General Assembly, the casino revenues, such as they will be in terms of the amount, those will be a bit delayed.

[02:55:24] So those will kind of trickle in? Yeah. Okay. At this time, I would like to have someone make a motion on one of these options that has been presented. Madam President, I'm not sure which of the options yet, so I'd like to share some context from the field and maybe, I don't know, I definitely agree there are procedurally working with motions, but in this case, we have choices.

[02:55:50] I'd like to have the opportunity to brainstorm and again, maybe some people have some elegant solutions. So again, first I commend staff for bringing us some options and it might be the will of the board that we have some sort of amalgamation alone. So here's kind of what I've received some feedback from the field, from some school divisions in six and seven, is that the idea of moving from 65 to 60 points, there's the changing the line.

[02:56:18] And then what does that do? Does that help us use the unused $85 million? Is that, you know, how does that work out? There's also feedback. Again, this was the first time. Again, we talked about coming through construction zones. You learn, we're learning by doing. Some school divisions, while we think gave good guidance and the school building conditions, definitions, et cetera, some school divisions probably applied overly strict interpretations of some of the definitions to themselves, while other divisions maybe had less strict interpretations.

[02:56:49] And so I there's I think there's a desire for divisions who were hoping they could get rescored and that, you know, that again, there was nothing wrong with the scoring process to to engage in that piece of it. So I don't know the best way to get at that and what ideas, you know, the staff may have, but I don't want to like to slow down a little bit before we say, oh, we're gonna move from 65 to 60.

[02:57:14] um and are there other things we could do under the hood uh to provide some clarity there and and i don't exactly know what they are because this is in the facilities realm mr rotherham mr dick i have a question so the intent of the general assembly my understanding is to drive this to high poverty high need so high fiscal need areas when we think about these three options like just for starters like which of them is more likely to have that and and by the way i think that's a goal that it's a goal that I think this board shares I certainly share um which of those three options is more likely to help us stay in alignment with that goal or achieve it well I we

[02:57:54] believe that that was the intent and desire of the program and the general assembly and governor as well um and as you know obviously there's huge backlog of capital projects statewide you know lower resource school divisions have difficult financing capital projects.

[02:58:13] There's billions and dollars of needs statewide, but across the state, all sorts of school divisions. It may take several rounds of this grant program to address some of the most severe building needs in the state in school divisions that can least afford capital projects. In that regard um you know we feel like the 11 criteria um are in alignment with the appropriation act language um in terms of student demographics community demographics ability to pay of

[02:58:50] localities uh and so perhaps um you know proceeding um with the program unchanged for you know a few more rounds of funding to address some of those most severe needs in the in the in the school divisions least able to afford it may may be an approach okay i don't yeah i don't want to put words in your mouth but it seems like the first option is the one you're describing and it seems like if we go deeper into the pool we could possibly dilute we could possibly dilute that if we just decide to just go deeper down on the scoring metric because it's a cumulative

[02:59:24] set of points so we don't know how they got those yeah and i will say we've looked at the data um if the minimum point threshold was lowered to 60 on the initial round of applications that would fund about 55 million in additional projects 12 schools um henrico county montgomery county um a variety of uh in in about five six school divisions so that would be the immediate impact of lowering the the initial cut score down to down to 60. it would bring in 12 more projects

[03:00:00] at 55 million of the 85 million available but yes they would be less likely to meet the original criteria of the 65 on the rubric okay yeah yeah i appreciate that that sounds important thank you a question for mr dickey i think i now have my item number uh in front of me we heard at public comment this morning uh comments from the virginia school board association president-elect

[03:00:33] cardel and he asked that we consider this item on first review today and await final review at the next board meeting to allow school divisions to provide feedback on the question you know on this exact question you're asking us which of these four options or option four including other potential changes he also suggested that there conceivably could be some action in the general assembly uh on the budget that might be relevant to this um um matter do you do you have any reaction

[03:01:08] to our feedback force on that and particularly to the question of generally i like to hear from the stakeholder major stakeholder groups the sba being one that has both knowledge and interest in helping us get this right um is there any harm in doing our in waiting final review as we normally would at the next meeting or is there a reason to rush today or a reason to do it today and or any other reaction to those that feedback yeah that that's just a tough balance you know as we all know i mean a huge backlog huge demand i mean many school divisions that would you know meet meet the point

[03:01:46] criteria as they exist are ready to move forward um they they would you know certainly be happy to submit additional applications for other schools in their division that they didn't submit in the the first round and they would be ready to go um and and you know meet the meet the board's criteria um uh the um but by the same token that the the money is now you know it's not subject to reversion it's it's in the statutory fund it's that it was also created at the 22 session so it's it's in

[03:02:21] in a dedicated non-reverting fund that was the intent to allow flexibility across fiscal years But, you know, from a school division perspective of the neediest and least ability to pay, you know, their ask is always going to be to move forward as quickly as possible.

[03:02:42] Mr. Dickey, question for you. So, if we only take this item for first review today, not first and final review, is it true or not true that these projects that are sitting in the hopper would be negatively affected by the continued increase in construction costs and the ever-increasing interest rates that are set to increase again in September to affect those construction costs?

[03:03:12] yeah there's uh you know with with um a cycle of several more you know another board meeting and then you know depending on the august schedule you know that potentially could put final action out you know two or three months and then and then to you know um set up and queue up another round of applications that that is a concern i mean you know cost or you know construction costs you know continue to escalate you know moderating somewhat you know interest rates um you know the highest they've been in you know over a decade um with and probably uh you know haven't topped out

[03:03:49] yet so that that is a concern with time and cost and interest rates you're you're correct um before i accept uh comments from people who have already spoken please uh if you have not spoken and wish to speak dr northern so just to clarify are you saying that even if we were to lower it five points that we would be back here again because we're still going to have how much, what was your estimate on how much money would be left even if we lowered it to five points? That would spend $55 million, so about approximately $30 million. $30 million left. Okay. So is that what's going to happen? Will we have, even if we were to do this today, will we have another conversation

[03:04:28] just like this one? I think we would be back discussing some of the same issues. At the same time some casino revenues likely will move into the fund a relatively limited amount so that 30 million dollars could you know be somewhat higher from the initial casino revenues coming in as we understand it okay so we could feasibly get um input from stakeholders for the next pot of money we're gonna have to spend i guess as if we were to okay thank you mr sturdifant or miss kilgord

[03:05:05] either one of you wish to speak on this item she had the question i was thinking about so you you answered it yes madam president um also if we keep the level the same at 65 we know that's going to fulfill the need of the most needy schools as opposed to luring it to 60 correct so we can move forward today at the current number that we have and those schools divisions will automatically start receiving the

funding without delay yeah of course you know nothing's affected by what's already been awarded we're moving that you know we're implementing those uh grants with school

[03:05:41] divisions uh for the remaining funds um a scenario where we would move forward with no changes to the criteria guidelines you know we would as quickly as possible move forward with you know another round of applications under all the current requirements and criteria you know which would presumably um be targeted at the you know same population of communities localities student of populations. And did you say that was your recommendation to keep the level at 65 to move forward for another round? I think there's some benefits to doing that. Again, addressing some

[03:06:21] of the highest need projects around the state that allows us to move forward quicker than then um uh a another uh round of review uh where that may put another round of application process start up uh deeper into the fall time frame um so that would be a more expedient way to move on another round of applications i think are the benefits to doing that madam president um with that benefit i will support the first and final review with the

[03:06:55] 65 never staying the same and just moving forward with it today is is that emotion yes okay can you give us that first option again so we're all clear that's we're going to re-compete based on the current standards so the motion would technically be correct me if i'm wrong kent wave we would waive first and final review and um proceed with another open application process for school divisions with no change to the program guidelines for scoring criteria that would be the motion is that correct mr start of him yes madam president thank you yeah i don't mean to put you on the

[03:07:34] spot but i do have one question second we need to get a second a second okay now we can have discussion i don't mean to put you on the spot i do have one question did we learn anything through this first process that we may want to change any of the point ordering to the are there any lessons where if and as you said everyone from the governor the assembly the board is in agreement we want to to send this to high property communities did we learn anything do we want to make any modifications to the scoring system or do you feel like the is the position of the department the current scoring system is achieving that goal pretty effectively yeah i think with the the the intent and the goal of the general assembly and the governor governor to focus at least initially these limited funds on

[03:08:12] the on the neediest localities and the highest priority um projects um we we think that does that and and i i i think you know some of the house preparation staff input was in alignment with that of course but um as um additional rounds occur as additional revenues come in into the fund um perhaps you know the criteria point values to to bring in a broader array of communities or projects could be done because at that point um you know the highest need projects have had several

[03:08:49] you know bites at the apple for funding and so you know perhaps in a year or two um depending on the penetration of the funding some you know the individual criteria or point values could be adjusted and revisited to bring in a broader array of school projects that makes sense it does thank you any other discussion on this item yes ma'am president um dr siebert couple of things first question so if this motion carries um and the application process is reopened would existing divisions be able to reapply uh as if as they work with you all to understand the conditions

[03:09:29] definitions document and those kinds of things could there be reapplications for yeah um for the same same school division same school projects conceivably yeah yeah so that there's no prohibition i can't think of a a um a reason that couldn't occur and i mean you all do tremendous job with

communication and engagement and and you know your team vj everybody's wonderful to work with i would encourage maybe one or two webinars about how to use the conditions document just to just i just think some you could do pretty easy for for divisions to to you all learn from

[03:10:06] the process divisions apply to learn from the process you may have a couple divisions share but for for them help you know just especially those that have small expertise and we rely very heavily on on your team for those things i think that would be be very helpful thank you and i and i will mention madam president very quickly there's another code requirement we're in the midst of this project um bj ramner rain director of support services working on this we're in a data data collection with department of general services which dovetails state capital projects

[03:10:37] using their life cycle value building analysis for public school buildings. And that was legislation that passed at the 2022 session. It's an extensive data collection for 2,400 school buildings.

[03:10:55] In part, you're hoping that data, which gets to very discrete conditions of the building, will be able to be used in this program in the future. but that's going to be down the road as we go through the initial data collection process with school divisions. That's months out till we complete the first round, but that data may have promised to get at building conditions in a more systematic way. Other comments? Ms. Holton.

[03:11:27] Just briefly, now that we have a motion on the table, it is, my gut says we should wait and hear from the sba and others pursuant to mr patillo's suggestion this morning but if it's the will of the board that we could do this on final review today i will uh vote i because i do support the proposal option one so i just wanted to say that by way of explanation of my vote if if that's the if if they're not interested in waiting final review and another need other comments okay we have a

[03:12:03] motion made and seconded on the floor to waive first review and proceed with another open application process for school divisions with no change to the program guidelines or scoring criteria. Ms. Kilgore, how do you vote? Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Dr.

[03:12:26] Northern? Aye. Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. President votes aye. Motion passes. we are going to at the discretion of the chair move to item i as we have guests here prepared to see that item so item i everyone my understanding is that we're going to have two presentations on this item one from mr chapman and one from dr mcknight at bcu mr chapman president creasy

[03:13:01] vice president hansen members of the board dr coons i have the really distinct honor of presenting what to the best of my knowledge is the first laboratory school application that this public body has considered so this is a really wonderful time you know for state government an initiative that started last year with governor youngkin and has been through quite a process i will i'll tell you at the outset one of the things that we have learned in the process of establishing re-establishing the college partnership laboratory school standing committee

[03:13:38] and reviewing applications is the idea that any one person would know enough to fully vet an application to stand up a school is is just amazing there's probably only a few people in the state who have the the knowledge of all of the different bodies of law and areas of school administration in order to get it all right on first review i think if i can brag for a second And fortunately, I think we are lucky enough to have one of those folks as our superintendent and also as our chief of staff, Dr. Rayleigh.

[03:14:13] For the presentation this morning, I would love to start off with just a brief definition of what college partnership laboratory schools are under Virginia law, before moving into the application process that's been established by the standing committee.

[03:14:28] And then we are gonna hear from the representatives from VCU, Dr. McKnight, and about the particularities of their proposal.

[03:14:46] So under Virginia law, College Partnership Laboratory School is a public, non-sectarian, non-religious school in the Commonwealth established by a public institution of higher education, a public higher education center, institute, or authority, or an eligible private institution of higher education as defined in state law.

[03:15:05] And the emphasis here is really that the board is establishing a public school. This is not a private school. This will become a public school that should be accountable, as other schools in the Commonwealth are. The lab school legislation states specifically that these are supposed to remain subject to the standards of quality, to the standards of accreditation, and to the standards of learning.

[03:15:29] And in Virginia, lab schools are designed to do a few main things. The first is to stimulate innovative programs, provide opportunities for innovation, also providing teachers with avenues for delivering innovative instruction, and school scheduling management structure.

[03:15:49] They're supposed to encourage performance-based educational programs, establish high standards for teachers and administrators, encourage greater collaboration between pre-K and post-secondary school providers, and develop model programs. tell you having been with the standing committee and seen a number of the proposals for lab school applications that have been submitted governor youngkin when he started this initiative he really rang a bell about innovation in virginia and i think what we've seen is that the sheer variety of applications that will be moving before this not only the standing committee but eventually before this board is extremely impressive we have everything from marine

[03:16:27] and coastal industries to aerospace technology to healthcare um i mean this is a a really vast spread um you know the industries and public higher public institutes of higher education they've really responded to this call the proposal before you today is going to hit on a number of these areas but i'll highlight the innovation that's already a hallmark of the code rva high school and also the high teacher standards that we've come to know from virginia commonwealth university and their teacher residency program so one of the important things to know about this is

[03:17:04] that there has been a standing committee of the board that has uh has been working very very hard in order to establish a process fitting of vetting an application that's here for you today the standing committee met when the original legislation was passed back in 2012 and then there was a significant hiatus i believe about nine years but then um this committee was was reformed by president gecker in december of 2022 and the members of the chair or the members of the committee are as follows we have joan wadiska who's a former vice president of this public body

[03:17:40] dr pam moran who's a virginia school administrator professor at william and mary john bailey who is an education expert from northern virginia and then members of the board of education vice president hansen and also mr rotherham this committee has worked really tirelessly they have been holding a public meeting schedule that has rivaled your own not only had did they meet and for planning

meetings in december of 2022 and february of 2023 they have held public meetings which have been reported to this board on regular updates in march in april and june and july of

[03:18:14] this year the standing committee was formed and they had a number of things to accomplish and we were standing up a standing committee and so they had to not only come up with a process for reviewing applications they also needed to standardize documents such as application rubrics compliance reports and reports to this board all of which you see as part of your agenda material this is a significant amount of documentation that was generated by staff and by the standing committee. They've also had goals to revise the current lab school application,

[03:18:49] which they finally completed at their last meeting. That application we found was not only ill-suited to getting the types of information that was helpful for the standing committee and ultimately for this body, but it was also in a file format from 2008 that was hard to open using any kind of modern software luckily those problems have been worked through and they also wanted to review lab school applications that have been received by this board which at this point i believe we're up to including the vcu application today before applications and then they've also been receiving public comments as you know this body receives

[03:19:27] public comment on all matters related to public education virginia um the labs the standing committee uh humbly takes only its part and receives public comment on matters related to laboratory schools in virginia so i'd love to go over the application process and the full life cycle of a college partnership laboratory school application as it's been devised by the standing committee the first thing that the standing committee wanted to do and again realizing how difficult it is for any one person to to hold all the knowledge that's necessary in order to review

[03:20:03] these applications is they set up a subject matter expert group. So the SME there is for subject matter expert group, and they had a few main goals. The first is that they would review these applications for completeness and compliance under Virginia law. They would fill out a rubric and make sure that was provided to the standing committee so that they would know that this application had in fact been vetted. And then they would provide technical assistance to applicants through an iterative process. This has been a major focus of the Standing Committee under the leadership of Ms. Wadiska and certainly joined by Dr. Raley, that they wanted to emphasize coaching

[03:20:41] instead of compliance. The Standing Committee strives for compliance and documents the processes it has thoroughly, but the tenor has not been to provide applicants with a here's a list of what's wrong, thank you and goodbye, but rather to adopt an attitude of let's get there. And so when we We started receiving these applications from a number of different schools as far back as August, September of last year.

[03:21:06] There have been constant dialogues with applicants, even to make sure that the application is ready to be reviewed by the Standing Committee, because the Standing Committee knows that ultimately that's going to be posted for public comment. We want to make sure that that is pristine and at least the threshold issues have already been worked out.

[03:21:25] Once the VDUE subject matter expert group has reviewed this application and cleared it for the technical components and for compliance, that application then goes to the standing committee. And the standing committee has asked even more questions on everything from government structures and then,

you know, beyond physical sustainability, which I think was a major emphasis in reviewing these applications, is that this be a viable long-term project of the laboratory school.

[03:21:52] But also for terms that are new to someone like me for structural sustainability, making sure that these schools have the resources in the community, partnerships with industry in order to be a viable program of innovation and making sure that students and families are able to benefit from this.

[03:22:14] They would refer the application for public comment. They would follow the board process of reviewing twice. And so this application was heard on first review. They were asked questions. They provided some additional information. The application was posted for a 10 working day public comment period. And then it came back to the standing committee on second review, and even before it was referred to the board.

[03:22:40] And now, proudly, this application is before the Board of Education for you to evaluate and to consider this application. And to make sure, again, we want to make sure you are aware of how many folks have been involved in this process in addition to the standing committee.

[03:22:56] These are the members of the VDOE subject matter expert group. The leadership starts at the top with Dr. Raley, the chief of staff of the Department of Education, and of course himself, a former division superintendent of Goochland County. Dr. Rayleigh has added a lot of cohesion to the group and really mobilized staff in order to set the tenor for this review process.

[03:23:17] We've had Mr. Kent Dickey, who you just heard from, who's the Deputy Director of Budget, Finance, and Operations. Dr. Samantha Hollins, Assistant Superintendent of Special Education and Student Services. Ms. Melissa Velasquez, an Assistant Superintendent of Policy and Communications.

[03:23:34] Dr. Brendan Albin. At the time, he was the director of STEM and Innovation, but now is an assistant superintendent over school quality. The committee or the subject matter expert group had a quota for persons named Jim. So I gladly stepped into that role and was helpful, I hope, in reviewing these applications, but also Ms. Maggie Clemons, the director of school licensure, licensure and school leadership, Mr. Edward Lanza, director of budgeting, Ms. Amy Siebka, the director of accountability.

[03:24:04] Ms. Susan Williams, Director of Data Services, and Mrs. Rebecca Askew, our Senior Policy Analyst at the Department. That's a brief overview of the process. If you have any questions, I would love to see if I could help address those before we turn that over to our representatives from VCU, Dr. McKnight, Dr. Borenson.

[03:24:24] Dr. Northern. Is there any process in place, not just for the school, but I mean, is the standing committee working on a process by which the schools will be regularly evaluated?

[03:24:39] just to you know a continuous loop of you know how you do and what are your needs and something you know that that sort of is uh monitoring them but in a helpful capacity you know not just um i'm just concerned about and not really concerned but just since this is so new to us that we have a mechanism in place for just seeing how they're doing you know and evaluating them informally as they roll out it's not like you got to hire an external evaluator for a gazillion dollars but just some kind of uh process in place mr chasman yes dr northern there have been there have been a number of emphases not only from um miss wadiska but also from the the larger initiative

[03:25:18] from the secretary's office to start creating learning communities of lab schools and so you know not only is this present with the planning grants we've already had one uh innovation incubator uh you know in order for those folks to get together but the plans are you know as these applications move before the board as these schools are established to continue forming those same learning communities so they can even within the network of lab schools share best practices make sure that they're learning from each other and of course the unique part of this situation is that this is the first lab school that will be you know approved in addition the contract that the board will be required to enter into is going to have some of those same hooks to make sure that the lab

[03:25:57] school is collecting data similar to what's collected from public schools so that we we do have that same robust understanding of what's happening in these schools dr hans as i mentioned this morning we have a brand new assistant superintendent of innovation starting on monday who will oversee this one of his first roles is to create that network in that regular community of feedback loop and support so we're really excited to have andy armstrong start that on monday but that will be one of the first things he does is both has a network for existing lab schools and also those aspiring planning grant ones with experts from around the nation giving them support

[03:26:34] so really excited good question and his first day on monday will also be a meeting of the college partnerships standing to pity he brings lots of innovation from butchland county so i'm very proud miss holton uh thank you uh mr chapman and thank you to the lab school application committee members who've worked both from this board and and more generally who've worked so hard on this i'm a huge fan of both the richmond teacher residency program and the code rva program long-standing wonderful

[03:27:07] partners in our education community here in the richmond region and a long-standing champion of them so i'm happy to have them coming together as i understand the benefit of now having these really existing programs come together under the rubric of a lab school is partly just the combining them and so that teacher residents will be trained as part of computer science education etc at the new lab school i i understand that benefit of it help me make sure i'm right that

[03:27:43] that's really the primary benefit is it also the case that the application will expand the capacity of each of those programs i think i saw something that said the school will go from 345 students up to 400 students so adding 50 some students will there also be expansion to the capacity of richmond teacher residency as part of the lab school funding process i'm getting head nods in the affirmative from the folks at vcu but i do think that you emphasized one thing very very well that yeah the result here is going to be more than the sum of the parts um you know we're we're really

[03:28:21] excited the standing committee was very excited about this application and the kind of symbiosis that was going to result from this how it's going to add capacity this is going to be some really fun directions so and i also see if i make a follow-up question i see reference to maybe eventually adding an elementary and a middle school that would come back before the lab school committee i take it before there was an expansion with further details as to the plans before we we're actually adding new grades we believe so the request and the superintendent's recommendation which has been updated for you um in order to get make sure we got some procedural things correct

[03:28:58] with uh with oag about how this needs to happen next few days um it's going to be that this is a three-year approval um to start and so the board would get those chance to evaluate at a a good what we

think is a good interval but specifically that that the approval is for the expansion of the the high schools that's correct as laid out and the combination of RTR and the existing high school rather than a new elementary or middle school at this point we're not being asked to approve that at this point that's my understanding that anything beyond would be a substantive change and therefore have to come back to this body thank you that's

[03:29:37] correct Ms. Holton as you as you likely know the board is going to be required to sign a contract with the board and so part of the the recommendation from the superintendent is that that final execution of the contract be delegated to President Creasy and to Dr. Koons. And large part, some of that's the formality.

[03:29:52] You might recall from the board bylaws, Ms. Abby Gump from OAG did mention during that presentation on Tuesday that the superintendent and the president are both required to be signatures of any contract executed by the board. So that made procedural sense from that standpoint.

[03:30:09] But in that contract, it will be for the approval that's on the table for the applications on the table so yeah any expansions to that proposal we believe would have to come back before the board can i just before i'm really excited to hear this has been a lot of work mr rotherham that's one of the two points i want to make uh it's been a lot it's been a jim named all the people has been just a tremendous amount of work including just a lot of people just i mean you know a lot of folks work for the department have put in a lot of time and then a lot of citizens have put in a lot of time and the applicants so i'm excited uh for you to hear what you're going to hear and then the second thing just to sort of set up a little bit

[03:30:46] something ms holton said that i think before the delightful digression into procurement policy um was talking about teachers and i think we tend to immediately default when we talk about these lab schools we talk about choices for families and for students which is great and having more choice for students is great but i think we we can quickly overlook that environment of more choice and innovation creates more opportunities for teachers to do different things try different things um uh find workplaces that are maybe more more in alignment with their various uh you know interests educationally pedagogical approaches and i think that's been like an overlooked part of this conversation is the just tremendous opportunities that if we continue down this

[03:31:25] road it's going to create for teachers and you're going to hear about one shortly is that it for mr chapman okay thank you dr mcknight um i and dr gorenson um thank you so much for being here today and for your patience we wanted to save you guys a little bit to get to your serious work so thank you for being here thank you so much we're gonna oh there it is good afternoon uh president creasy vice president hansen dr coons and members of the board thank you for this opportunity my

[03:32:03] name is dr kim mcknight and i'm the director of virginia commonwealth university's center for teacher leadership in the School of Education. And I'm Dr. Kimi Gorenson, Executive Director of Code RVA Regional High School. And can you all hear us? Are we good? Doing okay? I know we stand between you and lunch, so we're going to do our best to keep it going. So as we think about the future of teaching and learning, we know we're in a critical shortage for high quality educators going into the field. And we also know that we are looking for pathways both in teacher education for innovative practices, but also thinking about what schools need for comprehensive access

[03:32:41] for students. And specifically in this case, we are looking at computer science and workforce development. And so we're going to go through just a quick what RTR is, what Code RVA is, our next step,

and then questions. So what's RTR? It's formally known as Richmond Teacher Residency, and we are currently in our 13th year. We began as a partnership with Richmond Public Schools and have since expanded to 16 school divisions across the commonwealth we've prepared 314 teachers in high needs schools and trained over 239 mentors we are so proud of our graduates that include the

[03:33:19] current richmond public schools teacher of the year is both a graduate of rtr and a current mentor for a future teacher for in a science classroom and was actually visited by the president of the national science foundation for exemplary practice of instruction in addition we've had individuals even from cohort one who are still teaching in richmond public schools so that's 12 years later still at armstrong high school and so for us this is about recruitment preparation support and retention of high quality teachers and teacher leaders our goal is based on a medical residency

[03:33:55] where someone who wants to become a teacher is working alongside a rock star teacher from the first day of teacher work week until the last day of school while they're doing their coursework and then it's called a gradual release of responsibility and then by the time that they become the teacher of record so they are not responsible as the teacher of record yet they have learned alongside a really strong mentor and as we look at sort of our our framework here We have a mentor framework and career coaches, as well as an added a school leader residency.

[03:34:27] And so we have been training special education, secondary, elementary, and we've since added school leadership. And that's where they're getting a postmaster's certificate in educational leadership while working alongside a rockstar school leader like Dr. Gorenson. My favorite statistic to say is that 99% of our mentor teachers say that being a mentor made them a more effective teacher.

[03:34:50] We talk a lot about trying to recruit into the profession, but we're not talking as much about retention. It's one thing about a bonus, but teachers want to be leaders, and when they feel that they're growing the next generation of teachers, it makes them want to stay. So there was a question around evaluation. We've been federally funded, we'll talk a little bit about this later, through the U.S. Department of Ed for 12 years, and there is an extensive evaluation that we have to collect. We've been state funded, and there's also a cost share with school divisions in

[03:35:20] this. But the number one reason that our residents or graduates leave is that we do exit data. And it says that there's a lack of administrative support, which is why we added the school leader residency. And so one of the things we love about our models, not only are they working alongside a mentor who goes through a very rigorous application process to become a mentor, but they also get two years of support from a career coach. This is someone from outside of the classroom that's coming in an hour every week in their first year and an hour every other week in their second year. And for that, it's really that framework you see on the side where we really want to focus on teaching them about professional voice, instructional support, and social-emotional

[03:35:59] learning. And for me, it's all about how do we amplify teachers' joy and the love of teaching. Thank you. And we just have a couple short slides on CodeRVA, but happy to answer any questions. And as always, I start with an open invitation for anyone that would like to come and visit. I love to do tours. Code RVA has been open since 2017. I am the second Executive Director at Code RVA, and it's a pleasure to serve there. We serve 15 different school divisions across Central Virginia. Some of our students ride over an hour to get to Code RVA and have the

[03:36:35] opportunity to interact with students they might never have met, and it truly does prepare them for the workplace. You can see all of our partners listed there. We already use lottery system which has been very successful in creating a representation of our partner school divisions at our school we do not we are the only lottery that does not require any pre-admission criteria or prerequisites every student has equal opportunity to apply for a seat at code rva we do not screen students out based on math scores or previous courses taken or admission criteria it

[03:37:09] is a true lottery and so our students are admitted in that manner and it really we talked to her the word choice just a moment ago we are truly a school of choice for families we tell them that they choose us by applying to the lottery and then the lottery chooses them and then they choose to partner with us and so it is um it's a wonderful setting for families uh we learn already on an extended school year schedule our students do follow a regular academic calendar similar to school divisions but then we include an additional 20 days in the summer for students our teachers are 11 month teachers and so based on students needs such as for remediation or acceleration

[03:37:47] because we do offer dual enrollment coursework students have that opportunity to learn and school divisions transport our students for free so again these students have the opportunity to access this with no additional burdens to families our students do earn dual enrollment credit in a a variety of ways and we have four really four different pathways that students can go of course we offer a high school diploma just like every other virginia school advanced or standard um and in addition students can choose what we kind of think of it like mild medium and spicy right the spiciest path is a full associate degree in computer science through j sergeant reynolds

[03:38:22] it's a math heavy science heavy computer science heavy associate degree it's very challenging um If students what kind of more of a medium pathway, they can do up to 30 dual enrollment credits through Jay Sargent Reynolds, while still participating in code RVA computer science classes.

[03:38:39] We have a new pathway that we're excited we are one of the very few schools that partner with two different Virginia Community colleges. And those bodies came together to agree, so that we could expand offerings our students work with bright point in this upcoming year they can earn what's called a career studies certificate.

[03:38:57] And that is half basically of an associate degree with Bright Point. And so the students on that pathway would specifically earn credits in web design. And so it's more for the student who's maybe a little bit more artistic, more graphic arts oriented. And we did implement, thanks to an innovation grant this past year, an arts pathway for our high school degree students.

[03:39:17] And then within the high school pathway, they can earn three industry credentials if they're so interested through cybersecurity, hardware, networking and programming. So we offer lots of opportunities already for students very excited and then I'm sorry okay one of the questions that had come out was family engagement and how to does code rba engage with partner.

[03:39:39] parents and partner school divisions, we try to provide opportunities for both in person and virtual meetings. we're respectful of parents time and one of the things we heard very early on was I have to drive an hour for a 30 minute presentation. And that's not always great with my family schedule and we were able to respond immediately offering live streaming opportunities, we have that technology available so.

[03:40:02] All of our events pretty much are live streamed and they're also recorded and then posted publicly so that if parents who were in like sixth and seventh grade are wanting to learn more about code rva they can watch our open houses. That we just did and prepare and be thoughtful about selection so. These are just a few of the listings that we do again we we recruit in school divisions, I love going to visit middle schools and so I go and meet with.

[03:40:23] students and recruit them for the lottery process we offer regular things you're used to back to school nights we have you know events homecoming prom all those great things that make high school wonderful and then we have advisory committees for our specifically for our school counseling department we also it's not listed here but we do have a regional advisory council which is made up of business and community partners non-profit agencies higher education partners that come and advise code rva on our curriculum and then our activities and then also we communicate regularly and all of our parent newsletters are available publicly online so that any parent that would would miss something is able to pull that up we really do believe in transparency

[03:41:03] and communication with families and want them to have ready access to information and on the note of family engagement part of my heart is committed to this because this is what i wrote my dissertation on because i believe um and the whole topic was how to build trust between teachers and families of students identified with emotional behavioral disorders and so part of this when we talk about what code rba has done it's also around the training of the residents and the future teachers that they need to understand the strengths that every family brings and they are the child's first teacher and how instead of just being a content expert you are a partner in their education and that's all part of the training that they receive on the front end

[03:41:42] and so we're also really focused on intentional recruitment within the latin community and part of that we're so proud to be the only recipient in virginia for the augustus f hawkins center of excellence grant talk a little bit about what that means it's an increase we have the multilingual ambassador program at vcu that helps to recruit students from high school to go into college and hopefully teacher education but it's also a focus on the families to get them more engaged in in schools and really making sure that we are meeting the needs of every bilingual and multilingual

[03:42:18] learner and part of the grant is that every rtr graduate will receive a free english as a second or other language endorsement as part of their program and so a big question has been about financial sustainability and i think what's really exciting for two successful models to come together is that we are going into year 13 code rva is going into year seven and this has been through a combination um federally funds state funds school division investment vcu investment philanthropic and corporate partnerships and by doing this over time for us we are really trying

[03:42:54] to see this as the long game if this money is not here um how do we continue to meet the needs of all students and so um in the general assembly there is a teacher residency line item and there is a 33% cost share that school divisions are investing. And so that's part of what we do when training teachers. There's also what we're really excited about is looking at the Department of Labor through registered apprenticeships for teachers. And I'm going to talk a little bit about that. So for us, we want to have the idea that you can earn while you learn. No longer should student teachers, or in our case, residents, live on very little money while trying to become a

[03:43:34] teacher. And our focus is to grow your own, find teachers that are in teachers for tomorrow in high schools, and expand upon the proven success of our model, where we can also leverage other funds through Department of Labor. And so as we wrap up, for us, it's really, this is an opportunity to start to really grapple with these questions. What is the future of teaching, leading, and learning? What does it look like for workforce readiness? What does it look like for teacher preparation what does leading within this teaching and learning look like and for us by bringing these two programs and schools and and just the success we've already had to expand across the

[03:44:13] commonwealth for best practices and so there was a question around expansion within the high school model that was exactly right when we said that it's more numbers that would be increasing for code rba but it's more about teacher practices that we could have professional learning opportunities across the state and because we've been doing secondary elementary even down to pre-k our hope would be learning alongside code rva teachers that are doing computer science integration having these future teachers learn that and then across the state what would it look like for others to kind of learn what that is and how they could incorporate that in their own schools

[03:44:49] so we want that to be a hub for us it would be an opportunity as a learning hub so from here um we'd love to just open it up for questions we appreciate your ongoing support uh and time miss holton do you have a question yes thank you you all are both such innovators already your programs are such uh well-recognized innovations and i'm just delighted to have you all with us today uh i understand that part of the lab school designation will allow you to expand by about 50 students. On the one hand, I'd love to hear how many additional residents you'll be

[03:45:28] able to add and anything else about what is the value of the lab school designation? How does that enhance your capacity? Yes. So Code RVA, in addition to pursuing a lab school designation, is pursuing a permanent building site. For those of you familiar, we rent a space right now. And so we're looking, we're physically limited in certain ways by our current facility. And we also know that renting is not fiscally responsible for school for um the future and so we're looking to build um and be able to expand and offer additional programming for our students in addition to our arts pathway we really want to expand the music production um in computer science and so we cannot

[03:46:07] do that in the facility that we're in so we're kind of conjoining these things so as we're pursuing our capital campaign and building that's going to allow us to expand to those students over the three year period um and so we're looking for that and then like another benefit for us is really the access to vcu's resources um you know as i mentioned we have lots of dual enrollment offerings we're always looking for ways to challenge our students with rigorous coursework with access to additional teachers vcu's been a great partner already our students work closely with the davinci center for innovation in their junior and senior years as they do their internship projects and so

[03:46:44] we're looking to expand that partnership um and we just know that vcu has been a great partner already we're looking forward specifically um working with kim our teachers have done great work in learning computer science integration specifically in humanities and computer science there's not a lot out there right and we really are pushing that to say how do you not just teach computer science which we do well but how do other schools integrate within their disciplines we know that there's it's difficult to find computer science teachers but how do we take away that mystery of what is computer science and take somebody like me who is an english teacher and say you too can teach computer science and if you're not thinking about it here's the ways you

[03:47:21] can look at your curriculum and say this is an organic embedding in the lesson we're not about one-time only standalone lessons of computer science that's not an effective way to get kids to think differently what you have to do is embed computer science in the curriculum consistently across every subject area and we would love to be a place where teachers from all across the commonwealth can come and learn with us a little bit from us but also with us because we know there's lots of great ideas going on all across the state and we want to be that place where people just know you come to code rba you're having this like instructionally focused dialogue

[03:47:57] and we're all growing together to benefit students so that's and i can add on i i think the other piece for us is um i was a kindergarten teacher and what i found in my experience is that when i I went into a PhD program, and the first thing I thought was, I didn't know any of this research.

[03:48:12] I didn't know anything that was happening, and how do we connect research to practice? That's one of the strengths of the residency model, because they're doing their coursework while embedded in a clinical placement. And to me, as we think about lab schools, it is that idea of partnerships between higher education and K-12.

[03:48:29] And I think the beauty of Kumi and I have known each other for a long time, and I think part of that is the trust between she has wonderful things happening in her school and we have wonderful things happening in our center and the belief that resources can help bring that together and then help others across the commonwealth benefit that's the piece that when you ask the question specifically around how many more residents that's not really part of this first stage for us it's more about we want to make sure to kind of figure out what this looks like together for the computer science integration for teacher preparation and that's where the piece there's a lot of mystery around computer science right now

[03:49:03] And I don't see for at BCU, we're not doing as much around the teacher preparation side that embeds computer science. And so I think for us, that's sort of the first phase is for us to learn more about what each is doing to then benefit the future for teacher preparation. Other questions? Thank you so much for being here today. We really appreciate it.

[03:49:29] Thank you so much. Have a great day. Thank you. So with all of that excitement, the chair will entertain a motion to waive first review and approve the VCU lab application for a three year period with annual reviews and delegate to the president of the board and the superintendent final negotiation of the college partnership laboratory school contract with VCU, including awarding startup funds and up to six million in per pupil funding from the college partnership

[03:50:03] Laboratory School Fund in accordance with the board's guidelines. So moved. Second. Any discussion on that motion? Seeing none. Ms. Kilgore? Vote I. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hansen?

[03:50:23] I'll go back to him. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Sturdifant? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Mr. Hansen? okay um president votes aye and that motion passes and with that um thank you thank you thank you thank you very much and with that we will break for lunch and um come back at about 1 15. thank you

[04:32:01] And cool, thank you. All right, we are back in session and we will begin item F, please. So is there a motion to approve the item as presented and one eliminate grade eight writing SOL in spring 2024 to coincide with the implementation of the grade eight integrated writing and reading and writing test component as required.

[04:32:27] part of the grade eight reading sol test and adopt proposed guidelines um to recommend um grade five integrated reading shelly do you want to do your presentation before we take up a motion or if you want us to do the presentation that's fine otherwise we'll just take questions do you need no i i just um don't know what i know we're trying to really i appreciate what we're trying to procedurally so um okay i'm just curious because let's step let's step back and shelly let's have you do your presentation that's okay all right president creasy vice president hanson

[04:33:07] members of the board and dr coons this afternoon uh sarah susbury who's the director of student assessment and i are here to present to you for final review proposed changes to certain testing requirements for writing and you all heard a great deal about this in the june meeting so we'll go through this relatively quickly um as you all are aware we did uh staff did uh develop a new item type it's an integrator integrated reading and writing item type that will be administered as part of the grade five grade eight and end of course reading tests this item uh actually uses a passage that is non-fiction uh it's based on either science or history content students answer

[04:33:46] a couple of questions and then they have a prompt and they are required to respond to that in writing as you all are also aware we currently have a writing test in place in addition to our reading tests they are administered at grade eight and end of course those writing tests currently consist of two components there is a component where students are asked to respond to multiple choice or technology enhanced items where they are correcting uh writing that is written by someone else and then the second component they are provided with a writing prompt and they do

[04:34:22] they do write in response to that prompt there has been concern for a number of years that the configuration of those writing tests actually negatively impacts instruction because because the reading and writing tests are separate instruction often occurs separately when in fact to support good literacy instruction we really want students to be writing about what they have read so this new item type that we have developed does encourage students to write about what they have read and really supports that focus on literacy instruction in addition to the current

[04:35:02] grade a writing test and into course writing test until 2014 there was also a grade five writing test it was eliminated by legislation in that year and it was replaced by a requirement that school divisions certify that they have taught the content and that they administer some sort of the local alternative assessment to assess writing in grade five. And you do have information in your board packet about the details about those requirements. Today we are asking you,

[04:35:39] as President Creasy noted, to eliminate the grade eight writing test using your authority under the SOA concurrent with the administration of this new item type beginning in the spring of 2024. we're also bringing before you today updated guidelines for local alternative assessments this would replace the guidelines that were uh adopted by this board uh for 2021 2022 and beyond current set would be in place for 2023 24 and beyond and the guidelines do recommend that school

[04:36:17] divisions use the results of the integrated reading and writing items to meet the required the writing requirements of those guidelines we did at your request solicit extensive feedback from the field in addition to what dr coons had already gathered prior to the june board meeting and if you wish sarah can certainly summarize the feedback we have gotten you do have an updated board item in your packet um we have been getting lots of uh feedback in the last couple of days and sarah was up very late last night trying to integrate it all so thank you sarah

[04:36:56] so uh would you like to hear about the feedback just briefly if that's the will of the board yes please go ahead sure um if you could introduce yourself too yes i'm sarah new board members thank you i'm sarah susbury i'm the director of the office of student assessment um on the original board item we had only had 28 uh individual emails and we have now received 71 uh emails from from both teachers and administrators um the the bulk of the teachers were middle school teachers we had 23 emails from middle school teachers 17 from high school teachers and then nine from

[04:37:34] elementary school teachers we had a few principals that that uh commented and then also english language arts supervisors or coordinators commented and we also had four parents uh some of them had to do a role as a teacher as well um but we did have 45 individuals that supported the proposal to eliminate the grade 8 writing sol test uh and then we had 29 of those individuals of 29 additional individuals that supported the proposal to have school divisions be able to use the integrated reading and writing assessment uh as part of the reading assessment in place of the

[04:38:10] grade five local alternative assessment so the the vast majority of the feedback was very positive um in the emails that you received you'll probably notice that there were comments made about how this particular methodology aligns with the current research as shelley talked about for literacy instruction so um the one of the comments was that um removing the traditional writing assessment and replacing it with the integrated reading and writing assessment honors that important reading and writing connection if we want to see positive shifts in literacy development in virginia public

[04:38:46] schools changing how the state assesses writing is a huge step in the right direction um there were some high school teachers that expressed a number of high school teachers 20 i believe that expressed concern about uh implementing this at the end of course level uh having to do with an additional requirement for verified credit in that we're not able to at this point eliminate the end of course writing test so that would remain in addition to adding this integrated reading and writing component into the end of course reading test so there was definite concern about

[04:39:21] that um they felt that the in fact the comment was the integrated reading and writing end of course assessment is a much more practical and worthwhile measure of students knowledge and we hope you'll take our recommendations seriously to allow students to complete the integrated reading and writing test to meet graduation requirements rather than the the standalone writing sol test at the end of course level would you like for us to read the superintendent's recommendation again yes please okay the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board of

[04:39:55] education approve the following actions elimination of the grade 8 writing sol test in spring 2024 to coincide with implementation of the grade eight integrated reading and writing test component as a required part of the grade eight reading sol test and adoption of the proposed guidelines to recommend that the grade five integrated reading and writing test component serve as a measure of student writing and so i will take a motion at this time um there too what's with what's exactly

[04:40:30] what was just so moved stated um is there a second second okay miss kilgore oh discussion oh i'm sorry excuse me discussion i'm ready to roll is there any discussion uh i just i just thank you and especially thank you for bringing the last minute feedback and all the thoughtfulness i i just might i hope i hope i'm wrong with things like this i think this is a modernization of assessment that is necessary I absolutely think we learn to write read by writing and so this is

[04:41:08] this is good we need to modernize I do think that this is a little bit again often we're too slow this because it was a little quick so I think when you sometimes when you go from to you go on a little trip there could be some bumps in the road so there I just I would hope that if we get here to the spring and there's some data bumps that we remember that we did make a really significant shift in assessment um and that we just be mindful of that when next year's data comes in dr norther so i'm i'm new you guys obviously know um i guess one um question i'd have as we work with the um

[04:41:48] test vendor uh construction risk i mean so we're moving from a five paragraph essay to my understanding that was you know a silly prompt you know you land on the moon how do you survive to something that integrates what they've read which is obviously you know what we know is is best to do these days but my concern is that you know sometimes these constructive responses are one sentence sometimes they're two sentences sometimes they can be a paragraph so we are losing the ability or asking kids to write a five paragraphs essay to a constructive response that could be much shorter so as we work with the vendor you know we might we might have a two

[04:42:26] paragraph minimum writing or something so we just ensure that the constructive response isn't a isn't a sentence or two um that's it it's a very good point yeah respond president creasy please um so just to clarify even in the old writing test we didn't have it didn't have to be a five paragraph paper um but we do have sample papers that we use to identify each score point on the rubric that's used to score and so teachers are well aware of what the expectations are we also

[04:43:02] have an application called understand scoring that has the rubric that's used to to score all of the papers online for teachers to see it has annotations explaining how the rubric is applied and as we move forward with selecting anchor papers to exemplify the score points of the rubric for this new item type we will update that applications that will be really clear to teachers what the expectations are what is that expectation i mean can you write eight paragraphs can you write one sentence or will there be any length requirement at all for what's expected in terms

[04:43:39] of the writing there is not a length requirement but it's clear in the sample papers that if you only write one sentence it's very difficult to get above a one which is the lowest score mr rotherham yeah i mean i i share some let's give some of the misgivings i just i worry we we're approaching this in a piecemeal way um i mean i'll support what we're doing today because i think these these these are changes that there's some merit to them but you're hearing from high school teachers the kids are getting there they're not prepared you heard from some middle school teachers who said we're not even emphasizing this enough kids are coming into middle school

[04:44:18] i think i and you now have some high schools that are using relatively low level tests now as as a as a benchmark of proficiency which is sort of the end result of this and so i just think we need we need to move forward on this today but we do need to have like a step back because of the importance of writing at some point and and we're having obviously communities we're rethinking this we just don't want to lose sight of of just making sure we don't have that that at the end of the day the actions we take collectively have a net increase in rigor around writing and not a net decrease in this particular all these particular ones they make sense we just do not lose sight of

[04:44:56] the of the whole waterfront here so i just thank you i appreciate that we are getting ready as you know because you've had the presentation on the standards timeline um we are in the process of revising the ela standards which will drive the types of content decisions you guys are talking about in the

reading and writing for the assessment i think this is a structural shift and a structural design shift that will feed into that so i don't think we're doing i would like to do them both whole holistically but i think this structural shift will allow us to better integrate the high quality ela standards into the kinds of things that you guys are asking for in the

[04:45:34] assessment items yeah thank you that's exactly what i just want to make sure we don't lose sight of the big, again, I don't know if I'm supporting this today, but just doing all this side of the big picture here. Anything else? Okay. Everybody ready to vote now? Ms. Kilgore. Ms. Holton.

[04:45:58] Aye. Dr. Siebert. Aye. Mr. Hanson. Dr. Northern. Aye. I got him. I got him. Mr. Sturdifant. Aye. Mr. Rotherham. Aye. And chair votes aye. Motion passes. Thank you very much. Thank you.

[04:46:17] okay item g please um final review of regulatory actions following the 2023 session of the general assembly mr chapman do you have anything before i ask for a motion yes president thank you very much president vice president hansen members of the board dr coons what we have before you we discussed in part at the board retreat which is a series of exempt actions that we've bundled together in one nice package for you you might recall from what can only be described as a

[04:46:50] And this is a thrilling presentation on the regulatory process from Tuesday, that the exempt actions that we're looking for require that the board exercise no agency discretion when they're the result of a change in state law. So the text here and the changes are very, very, very low to the ground.

[04:47:08] It's no more than what was required by the bill and in order to enact the what the the legislature and the governor have agreed should be codified in the Code of Virginia. The highlights of those changes, chapter four of the acts of the assembly this recent year made a change in order to in the the special education regulations which is chapter 81 of your section of the administrative code to permit local educational agencies to shorten the deadline from 65 business days from the receipt, the date of the receipt of referral for initial evaluation or reevaluation of a child in order to determine

[04:47:47] the related services for special education and eligibility. We have made those changes almost exactly. The 65 is from the Code of Federal Regulations of 65 days, so we left that number just to make sure that we weren't losing sight of that for our school divisions. Chapter 7 of the Acts of the Assembly made a very thoughtful allowance for certain graduation requirements to be waived by this board upon the request of a parent of any high school senior who died in good standing prior to graduation of the student's senior year. And so we are amending the standards

[04:48:26] of accreditation in order to show that exact same language and that permission in Ural's regulations. And then chapter 748 provided some additional directions for the extension of three year provisional licenses issued to a teacher working in a school division. And it specifies that the division superintendent must provide satisfactory performance evaluations for the teacher that were during the three-year provisional license period. That such teacher was employed, actually employed, and received filed performance evaluations. So we have made some changes to the

[04:49:02] licensure regulations for school personnel in order to account for that statutory language. And then the final change is also to the licensure regulations for school personnel, which basically the the change allows for if someone was the the subject of a set of a founded complaint of child abuse or neglect.

[04:49:21] And the board went through the process of revoking that license, and then a court of competent jurisdiction went and and reversed the finding that such person could then apply for for

reinstatement under your regulations. have added that. The regulations are a place we think where a lot of teachers for that type of process, they would go to the regulations to look for the process. So it made sense that that was mirrored in your regulatory text as well. As you can imagine, there really wasn't any stakeholder engagement in these because these are the results of the legislative changes.

[04:49:52] And so we're presenting them to you here today. This recommendation from the superintendent is that the Board of Education waive first review and approve these changes to the regulatory texts. So, can I get a motion to waive, first review, and approve the regulatory changes as presented?

[04:50:12] So moved. I'll second. Any discussion? Seeing none, Ms. Kilgore, how do you vote? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hansen? Aye.

[04:50:28] Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Stardefen? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. And Chair votes aye. Motion passes. Okay, we are going to item H. First and final review of early childhood care and education fast-track regulatory action.

[04:50:49] Thank you, Madam President. Members of the board, again, referring back to that thrilling presentation on regulatory process. Here we have a fast-track action. The nature of a fast-track action is that the public body who's passing the regulation expects this to be a non-controversial item.

[04:51:08] This is the result of a legislative change, so it's one of, we think, the safest basis for a non-controversial action and we are doing very little more than what we think is necessary and presenting to you in order to implement the statute as it was written the code of virginia at 22.1-289.059 had previously required that early childhood care and education entity or all child day programs that care for children ages birth to five implement policies for the possession and administration of epinephrine in every such entity to be administered by a nurse an employee or an employee of a local health

[04:51:46] department this statute proved to be a little difficult to implement because when the board was directed to change its regulations a number of those entities are not in fact licensed by the board so over the previous legislative session a couple of house bills amended that same section in order to limit the scope of the requirement to maintain epinephrine at the child day center and to apply only to licensed child day centers and child day centers who participate in the child care program so the the subsidy that comes through state funding the law or federal funding through the state mechanisms the law also requires that the that each family day home provider and at least one other caregiver employed by such a provider in a family day home be trained in the

[04:52:26] administration of epinephrine and they notify the parents of each child who receives care in such family whether the provider stores an appropriate weight-based dosage in the residence or home in which the family day home operates we've affected these changes in the regulatory text of a number of the different chapters dealing not only with child day programs but also family day homes and family day systems all of them are covered under the definition of a child day program and we have in fact included the carve-outs that we thought raised it and in consultation with the office of the attorney general raised it above a pure discretionary change and the issue there

[04:53:03] being that the board already has regulations dealing for the administration of medication epinephrine and if someone was in fact qualifying under the statutory base we did not think the intent of the legislation would then to be to also require the licensee to comply with the board's regulations so we've

made that carve out very narrow in order to to account for what we thought the legislation was attempting to do the recommendation from the superintendent is that the board waive first review and approve the fast track action can i get a motion to waive

[04:53:36] first review and approve the regulatory changes as presented absolutely second okay um any discussion or questions by members of the board okay miss kilgore how do you vote ah miss holton dr siebert all right mr hanson dr northern hi mr sturdifant mr rotherham - Aye.

[04:54:03] - Chair votes aye. Motion passes. Okay. We are moving to our presentations and written reports. Are you up first? Yeah, you are up first. Don't go anywhere, please. We'll have an update on College Partnership Laboratory Schools from Mr. Chapman.

[04:54:22] Please proceed. - Thank you, Madam President, members of the board. The College Partnership Laboratory School Standing Committee had a meeting earlier this month, the result of which you have already heard, where they recommended and referred to this body, the first lab school application for VCU, which you approved just before lunchtime.

[04:54:41] The standing committee would like to offer the report from that meeting. There'll also be a meeting on Monday, but they would, I think, certainly like to extend their thanks. And they are very excited for the process that has been set up and that the board has delegated them the authority and responsibility they've taken very seriously.

[04:55:00] Thank you again to not only Ms. Wadiska, Dr. Moran and Mr. Bailey, but also, of course, to Vice President Hanson and to Mr. Rotherham. Mr. Chapman, do you have anything further on this report?

[04:55:17] Thank you. Okay, thank you. All right, so we will move to item K, please. We might need a few, like, five minutes in order to make sure we can get this presentation loaded. Okay, so would you like for us to just take a five-minute pause?

[04:55:34] Thank you, ma'am. Yes, sir. Done. Five-minute pause.

[04:55:38] This is going to be so good.

[05:00:19] Okay, and we're off again with item K, an update on teacher and school staffing vacancy dashboards. I'll take it away. No, no, no, sorry, excuse me. Dr. Coons would like to take a moment of personal privilege.

[05:00:37] So I have worked in a couple of states, and I have worked with a couple of different data IT folks, and I just want to shout out this team tremendously, because a lot of times data and IT sits here, and the actual strategic work of an agency or the needs or the focus sit here and these guys brought this to me based on conversations we were having about teacher vacancies and need so they saw a need in our education and our strategy and built a data system that helped us so i just want to like just take a moment to thank you guys because it is really impressive and special to have a team

[05:01:16] that thinks before you about the strategic work and helps you see the data and problem solve and think about it in a very special way. So I just wanted to take a moment to thank both of you because this is really cool what we're able to do, but it also really helps us be able to push the work and the strategic priorities in a different direction. And you did that before we could even think about doing it. So really appreciate the work. And there's two places we're going to highlight their work today. This is the first one.

Then we're going to preview, just preview, I promise, Paul, just preview one other really cool dashboard that they're working on. So thank

[05:01:54] you very much. I just want to give them a huge shout out and talk about how special their work is. Thank you, Doctor. Please proceed. Thank you. All right. Good afternoon, members of the board, president, Dr. Koons. So today, talking about the teacher vacancy dashboard. And so you'll be able to view this at your own leisure. Just going to give you some high-level introduction to it, orientation to what you'll be seeing, navigation tips and tools.

[05:02:16] But if you go to the DOE website and under State Board Data and Funding, Interactive Data Dashboards, and scroll down the page, Teacher and School Staffing Vacancy Dashboard is right there and can be accessed. - Madam President, may I do it?

[05:02:33] - Just to interrupt, can you introduce yourself and your sidekick? Maybe you've been before us before. - I absolutely have not been before you before. - Sorry, she bragged about you so much. want to know who we have. My name is Paul Cormel and I'm the Chief Technology Officer for the Department of Education. And who is your colleague? And this is Tony Schroeder and she is the data specialist who pulled together the data behind this as well as the visualizations. Other members of the team worked very heavily on the data collection and partnership with all the school divisions to make this data possible, but Tony is the one who actually did compile these visualizations.

[05:03:13] No, no, thank you. And so that's actually a perfect launching point. So the data that we're going to be looking at today come from either the 21-22 school year or the 22-23 school year as part of the positions and exits collection, or data collection.

[05:03:28] And so these data are collected each fall in conjunction with our school divisions. And so the data that we are viewing today are a little outdated. They are from the kind of midpoint of this current school that just wrapped up. But we plan on updating these dashboards yearly with new data.

[05:03:46] It's going to be a living repository where you'll be able to view trends year over year. And so some of these comparisons will be current year to prior year. And then as we are able to roll on the third year of data, since this data collection has only happened twice so far, we will then start some trending visualizations as well.

[05:04:03] So, as we move into this, there are several different tabs at the top across the screen, which are the different types of visualizations that you can see. And I do apologize for it being so small and distorted on the screen, but not a lot I can do about that.

[05:04:21] As you come down, there are different filters. We'll talk a little bit about some of them. You have graphical representations of the regions, as well as some more traditional bar charts that display the data as well. And so here, the map really does highlight by region the severity of our vacancy issue. And so you can see that in Region 7, Southwest Virginia, the degree of our vacancies is certainly lesser than as you move towards the eastern shore.

[05:04:52] On the right-hand chart, you're able to see both the 21-22 school year as well as the 22-23 school year, the vacancy rate by position type. And so here we have it broken out by teachers, non-licensed personnel, aides and paraprofessionals, administration.

[05:05:10] But you can also click into one of these and get even further drill-down information as to what specific aides and paraprofessionals are you interested in and see the details broken out. You can also change that because the rate is interesting. But also, if you look at just empirical unfilled positions, you can see the actual counts. And so while the rate of aides and paraprofessionals may be very high, the actual empirical need is much higher in non-licensed personnel and teachers.

[05:05:42] That's where we're missing the largest number, but number and rate have different utility when you're looking at this, because if you're missing one out of one auditory specialist for a division, that's a really big impact for that division, even though it's only one vacancy, but at the same time, currently being short 3,500 teachers in the state is a really big problem as well.

[05:06:04] So it's two very important different ways to be able to understand and look at the data. There's a lot of information here. I'm not going to go into all of it. I encourage you to take some time on your own. Feel free to ask questions. Our team is always happy to talk data.

[05:06:19] We are data nerds after all. But please understand that you can change, like I already showed you, the measure. You can drill by region, by division, or even down to individual schools if you want to get down to that level of granularity. And that's going to hold true across pretty much all of these dashboards that are going to have the ability to drill to that level of specificity to answer kind of whatever questions you may have.

[05:06:44] But with your permission, I'm going to move on to other screens. So next up is just looking strictly at the 21-22 school year and the vacancies that we have here. We have a similar dashboard for 22-23, as well as a dashboard kind of comparing the differential between those two.

[05:07:03] All three of those I can cover from this one screen just to try to not completely melt your minds with how many visualizations you're going to see, but there's a lot of information directly on the visualization about each region, their vacancy rate, and how many unfilled positions you have. But as you hover over it, you get some additional information that will allow you to do those year-over-year comparisons, both in terms of rate to see if the number of vacancy by rate has gone up, but also get the specific count of vacancy change.

[05:07:31] And so you can see in Region 4, just kind of jumping down, they actually have 345 or so unfilled positions more in the current school year that just wrapped up than they did in 21-22.

[05:07:47] So they're actually increasing the number of vacancies. They are trending the opposite direction that we'd like to be seeing. And unfortunately, that is true pretty much across the state. I'll highlight Region 7, as they only had a difference of half of a percent more vacancies this past year. That's the best. Every region did actually see worsening vacancy between the 21-22 and the 22-23 school years.

[05:08:15] And so, as we move into these other dashboards, it's just additional ways to drill into the information. And so, here we can see by region, again, those vacancy rates, but now you can also really drill into the specific subject areas. And it's interactive. So, if I were to click on Region 3, Northern Neck and Middle Peninsula, the bottom chart will also update. So, that way it's specific to that region.

[05:08:51] You can also do it in the opposite direction, where if you are more interested in specifically mathematics and what are our teacher vacancies looking like there, I can click on the lower section, and this upper section will repopulate with by region.

[05:09:06] Now I can understand what is mathematics looking like across the state. And you, again, have the option to drill down even further to sub-disciplines within mathematics, and that holds true for all of these different disciplines. So the amount of data here is honestly staggering. To go through all the data points would take way longer than I'm going to spend with you.

[05:09:26] At the top, there are, again, several filters. One that I do just want to highlight right now is that this school filter, open school filter button, looks a little weird. It's not necessarily perfectly intuitive. So I just want to show that if you do want to select by school, this show data at division, region, or school level, you do need to select school there.

[05:09:50] Then click the open school filter button. And now I can actually select a specific school that I want. It's nuanced. I just don't want you to get to the page and then be stumped or frustrated as to why you're unable to navigate to specifically. Let's look at Ebington High just for a second.

[05:10:09] So that way I can show you that it will in fact populate for a specific school. And so you can get, they're actually doing really well. They're only missing one visual and performing arts, sorry, 25% vacancy there. but I believe when I looked previously, it was actually one individual person that they were missing. And if you ever find yourself lost, most of the dashboards do have a nice little reset filters button. So that way you don't have to try to figure out how to back out what you did.

[05:10:33] You can just click that and start back over. So that covers most of the mechanics of the dashboards. And so I'm just going to really move through and then talk about the remaining pages and the information that you may find within. So this next dashboard, the previous one we were looking at was again more of the empirical information for a given school year that you selected this dashboard lets you compare years so this is now looking at year-over-year changes where again you can see that every region has more vacancies than they did the year before but as you start to drill down into sub areas you can see that in mathematics vacancies actually

[05:11:10] went down we hired or had fewer vacancies by whatever means necessary we had fewer vacancies in mathematics than we did the year prior. And again, you have the same ability to drill in to as much as you want. Here's a bit of a twist as we move into transportation. So school bus drivers, van drivers, things of that. Again, information here, there's not the same breadth of information. There just aren't as many transportation designations as there are educational or paraprofessional and administrative designations. But you are able to drill into your

[05:11:50] transportational information and vacancies by region, by school, and by division. And then the last two to highlight are going to show some of the more focused and specialized areas that I've heard has been a topic of discussion the last few days. So this one in particular is special education. And so this lets you look at not only the vacancies and information in special education, but you can see here in these donut charts how the special education vacancies in gray compare to those of non-special education. So while our teacher vacancy rate as a state may be 3.86%

[05:12:26] as a whole, our special education vacancies are over 5%, whereas our general education and support staff, it's only 3.6, getting us to that total number. And so you can really start to understand that, and here you can see the composition, while it only makes up about 15% of the total population of professionals in our school divisions, their vacancy rate is definitely higher than our other areas. And then you have all the same ability to drill into by subject, by region, school, division. Again, seeing those breakouts between how is this differentially

[05:13:02] impacting our special education population versus our general education population. And then the last dashboard that I'm going to go to is very much similar, but now it's looking at are English learners. And so those teachers who are dedicated to our English as a second language learners and getting to understand better, how are they being impacted by the lack of professionals that are really geared towards serving those students and their needs best. Thank you for your time. I know that was a lot. I tried to go quickly, but also give you a level of grounding that you could understand this. If you have any questions on the floor, then happy to address them.

[05:13:41] Thank you so, so much for this, because this is the kind of thing that I could just go down a rabbit hole for like a good five hours easily like it's you know the next morning it's um you know blurry eyed because I've been sitting at my computer just playing with this so um totally love this opportunity to be able to really um I mean it effectualizes a lot of what we have have been

[05:14:12] um so so unvisually clear on and so we really do appreciate it um any comments questions dr sievert then dr northam um yes kudos to your team i hope you all just feel lots of hats on the back and encouragement to again for leaders to have people who are looking around corners for them is very very helpful so that's great quality of work is great and now that you've built it you nobody ever wants to build something and have it not be used so you may already be thinking about

[05:14:46] this but i would encourage you to think about how um the hr directors maybe through vaspa uh could could have a webinar on this or you know maybe something happens with their regional superintendent meetings or whatnot but i think that this is this is neat but again right now the hr directors have their they're just right now trying to get staffed up for the school year so i i look for an opportunity to really share this i think it's a tool that they would be able to use and benefit from and again it's good for them but you also want to see your work put to good use as well if you don't advertise if you don't mind if i may respond to that um with some of the other

[05:15:23] initiatives that we do have going on one of the things that our area is talking about both internally to the doe as well as more broadly across the school divisions is building a culture of data literacy and data understanding and data informed decisions not all decisions necessarily need to be data driven but decisions should be data informed and so really trying to figure out how to highlight whether it's these dashboards new dashboards or things that school divisions are creating internally figuring out ways that they can make sure that they are making well informed decisions whether or not it ends up being the right one time will tell but making sure that

[05:15:57] you're making a decision that you feel well informed on is important dr northern i think along those same lines i mean this is incredible it has huge potential i mean one thing that i'd love to see it used for is for a potential applicant to go straight there click on the link and it takes me to the application in that district where that need is so we begin to see not just you know this is awesome informative um as a researcher i love it um but also just be able to use it as a recruitment tool like you know you don't have to go you can go and click

[05:16:32] here and i mean easily um it could be a direct link to an applicant you know if they could if if they could link to that. My other comment is that, you know, if we were able to build it out and use it that way, the integrity of the whole design is keeping it updated, right? So how often is it updated? It's a great question. So right now, this dashboard is updated once a year based on the data collection that we are getting. We are actively exploring ways to increase our data

[05:17:07] interoperability with school divisions, trying to, I'm not going to say get ahead because we're already behind, but react to the need for more timely and actionable data. Because you're exactly right. If we get this data based on what schools we're seeing in September, we get at the DOE in November, and we're able to update the dashboard in January, that's a lot of time. We've lost a lot of value and opportunity there. And so data inoperability is a big focus of our office heading into the next several years. And we've already been having conversations with

[05:17:43] Superintendent Koons around that. Because it is very user-friendly. That's what I was impressed with. And it does need, the board does need to get out to the average person to access it. But in what she said, if you get to a website and it is outdated, you know, It's a turnoff.

[05:18:03] But I commend you. I think it's great, and it should be used, and the ward does need to get out so people feel comfortable. No one is there and use that. Ms. Holton? I'm trying. Here we go.

[05:18:19] Well, this is, yes, very exciting, and I'm pleased to see that they're live already on the website. And I see that you've got not just this task force but a dashboard, but a learning needs dashboard and a national board certified one, I'd be interested in what's next, what's on you all's agenda.

[05:18:38] And I'll say with respect to the teacher issues, we have seen in various iterations data on teacher licensure status, provisional licensees versus fully licensed teachers, and also teacher experience level.

[05:18:58] I think we have an experience measure that's one year or more, but are you looking at any of that data and even potentially the ability to layer some of those? Maybe I'm too ambitious, but are you thinking about dashboards for any of those data pieces or what else are you thinking of for next? This is exciting. That is a great question. It's also a little loaded, so I'm going to try to

[05:19:27] tiptoe and not overstretch. And so some of it is that this is an early foray into the space of providing visualizations and tools from the state. And based on engagement from stakeholders, whether that be at the DOE, school divisions, or the community at large, that should help inform where we go next and what the largest needs are. But beyond that, we have identified certain things within the agency that we are already working on.

[05:20:02] Some of those are things that are more easily able to be a publicly available application and visualization. And some of them are things that are really geared towards school divisions that contain PII or sensitive information such that it can't be an external facing dashboard.

[05:20:21] Not promising anything, but some of the things that we have explored are there are school climate surveys And school divisions get a thick report that's static and not interactive and has, you know, not easily trending data.

[05:20:36] What can we do with that? Because they get that report and anecdotally we've heard not a lot of engagement in most divisions with that. And so that's one of the areas that we're looking in. It's certainly not the only area that we're looking in. We have some other tools that we've already been doing a lot of development work on in terms of identifying students that may need interventions or also comparing different student groups against their kind of counterparts and against many metrics from things around attendance rates and chronic absenteeism to disciplinary actions to enrollment in AP courses and post-secondary educational opportunities. And so really trying

[05:21:15] to span the gamut of the educational experience, but providing both at the divisional administration as well as the school administration level different and easy tools to just quickly get an understanding of where they may have disproportionality or opportunities for professional development or really arming them with the tools to make informed decisions around where do they want to go what decisions do they want what actions do they want to take rather than having to you know have an army of five people in each division that are doing the

[05:21:49] The exact same work. Can we have a team of seven at the Doe that knocks that out for 130 some divisions? Very helpful. Thank you. So I was just thinking, I thought it was really, you know, thinking on Dr. Northern's comment. You know, if it does become somewhat of an opportunity for it to be some kind of recruitment tool, I think you'll see more divisions that'll want to keep their information, their data as up to date as possible.

[05:22:15] And that's what we're really reaching for, right? Like, we really want to have that very timely data because, you know, you don't want to be the school division next to, you don't want to be the school division with 12 openings next to the school division with zero openings, right?

[05:22:33] And so those are the kinds of things that I think will really start to make this data a little bit more real time. Dr. Coons? I think one of the things that Paul said that I want to just reiterate, the challenge right now is the interoperability of different data systems.

[05:22:55] It's like you have different roads and you need a translator to get the data to cross over. So one of the biggest challenges is one of the things I would love this board to help us advocate for is for that interoperability in ways that's not cheap, that's not an easy fix, especially when you're talking about ages of systems.

[05:23:15] I know we talked about licensure earlier, but the licensure system, getting data systems and that interoperability is a major lift. I know your team just applied for a federal grant to get some additional funds to do that. But one of the things you guys are talking about on the back end of the usage is hindered by all those old roadways and getting those roadways to talk and translate together.

[05:23:40] So that is, this is the wizards behind the curtain, but we've got to get the roads for them to be able to get the data and the data system. But I agree, that would be tremendously helpful. They're doing amazing work on some old roads, so we just need continued advocacy to get those data systems and the data talking to each other in a very, you know, Google-ish way.

[05:24:02] And to tag on to what you said and what you said, we're also competing with other states for teachers, you know, who everybody's not just staying where they're from. more so when you have an impressive accessible website like that that's also impressive that you would need to have that tagged on to it but not just competing with fellow school systems but other states as well anybody else this is appropriate i can just add please just being more really more specific do you mind if you come to the podium please we we have to people who are

[05:24:40] watching online want to hear your voice hello everybody um so i was just going to add that voice specifically with paul we're working on the regional lab and governor school dashboard we expect that to roll out here very soon i'm finalizing the the data as it comes in it's looking pretty um we had a preview for you dr coon but we didn't get to it on our meeting um and then we also have enrollment

dashboard that's coming out that's going to be pre-pandemic, pandemic, and then post-pandemic. And so those are the two that we are literally

[05:25:17] working on now that I'm hoping my team will be able to push out here very quickly. And then we have her conversations about some stuff with Title I and about the provisional lab, but we're going to let Dr. Kuhn and Dave Myers and our team direct where we go next. But these are two that we are literally working on now that should come out pretty soon to answer that question. Then I just to point out one thing because i think it's cute the little eye at the top of the screen paul if you show our eye for instructions we thought this would be nice and you guys please give us some feedback we're always developing these so where you can see if you don't know how to navigate a

[05:25:57] dashboard if you click on the eye for information or instruction you can see which that there's four views and you can read how to hover over it how to filter down how paul was saying one of them's a little tricky the open the school filter with some little navigation with tableau a little tricky on that one what we had to do but we put out instructions in there for anyone that they should be able to hit the eye and see what we mean now we know we're kind of geeky folks the data folks in the back so anything that you guys give us for feedback would be really great to help make sure that everybody can understand what we're trying to get for us thank you guys so much we

[05:26:35] appreciate your team um and the work that you do so thank you thank you for your time okay um as item l is a written report is there any need for discussion of that report okay um and now we will have mr dickey come back and provide us um our esser update that we had on our agenda for

[05:27:09] yesterday. We will have him do this today. And thank you so much. You're welcome. And good afternoon again, President Creasy, members of the board, Dr. Coons. Kent, just really quickly before you begin, I just want to make sure that the record shows that we have amended our agenda to include this item. So thank you. Sorry. Thank you. Thank you. Presentation, fairly high level

[05:27:41] on the ESSER spending and ESSER funding itself. And of course, the title of the program, as we well know at this point, elementary and secondary school emergency relief funds or ESSER, provided in three tranches under three federal acts in the early part of the pandemic. Three acts passed by Congress in about a 12-month period with increasing amounts of awarded money to states under each of the three acts that are listed there for you and of course the k-12 related

[05:28:22] pandemic funds included other programs gear means for private schools other early childhood grants of course out of hhs s are by far the largest federal pandemic funding source for pre-k-12 to states and with broad areas of allowable use about 15 or 16 broad statutory areas of use both you know immediate response to the pandemic ppe the public health part of it then remote instruction return to school learning recovery coming out so broad broad uses with

[05:29:02] these funds. 90% of the funds awarded to states allocated to LEAs, local educational agencies, which are school districts or school divisions in Virginia, based on the Title I formula. That was the allocation methodology. And then 10% of funds available to states for state set-aside projects and state administration. So 90% to locals, 10% for state-level use.

[05:29:33] The American Rescue Plan Act, ESSER III, the last tranche of ESSER funds, included a prescription that 20% of the LEA formula funds be reserved and spent to address learning loss. And that's

been formulated formally in the spending plans and program applications, LEAs, school divisions, submitted to DOE.

[05:30:02] that's monitored and approved at the application phase in terms of application process. School divisions filed for all the ESSER funds, ESSER 1, 2, and 3 initial applications, but they could be amended or modified along the way based on stakeholder input, changing local needs, small technical adjustments to align expenditures and budgets.

[05:30:31] and that is certainly built into our process. We've had 1,600-plus of those types of amendments, many of those, of course, technical and minor with line-item adjustments for small tweaks to budget plans, but some larger-scale amendments coming out of local stakeholder consultation.

[05:30:55] And ESSER III requires the local stakeholder consultation every six months. And some amendments were significant when school divisions were approved to do school facility upgrades, particularly early in the pandemic. Divisions also submitted uniformly statewide at the direction of the governor, amended or updated S-3 spending plans with an express focus on learning loss. The impact of those resubmissions was an increase.

[05:31:29] redirection of funding on learning loss and probably 40% plus of local funding could reasonably, based on the staff review of the revised applications, be considered or classified as focused on learning loss. So that resubmission did have positive impact on directing plans and spending increasingly on learning lost. And of course, LEAs, they're required to post their

[05:32:04] local ESSER plans on their local websites. We're required to provide a link to those local websites, and we have that on our federal pandemic page where you can go to each of the local school division sites to review the plan. And then funding mechanics on some of the expenditure reimbursement data presenting in the next couple of slides, we pulled the data as of July 20th, fairly current. An important thing about looking at this data, like any other federal grant,

[05:32:43] because DOE reimburses after locals spend the money and file for reimbursement is oftentimes divisions have the funds obligated or even spent fronted with their local dollars but they have simply not yet filed for reimbursal the DOE some school divisions for cash flow they reimburse weekly or bi-weekly some monthly some on longer timelines if they can you know front that money and that's more efficient for them. They have that flexibility, but actual reimbursements by DOE

[05:33:19] from the federal grant funds back to the LEAs, back to the school divisions, that number is always going to lag and appear smaller than actual utilization locally that just hasn't been filed for reimbursement yet. They can do that as often as weekly using our online grants management system. Of course, many do, but that's available to them weekly, and that will be, I know for the Department for State Superintendent, will be an increased emphasis on more timely reimbursement submissions by school divisions. And then each of these grants,

[05:33:57] ESSER 1, 2, and 3, the obligation deadlines run September 30th, 2022, 2023, 2024, and funds must be obligated, a contract, PO, payroll, a local grant award, some local obligation or commitment to use the funds. Reimbursements are settled and come in in the fall by December 31, and then we liquidate all reimbursements by late January as the grants

[05:34:34] closed down. So that's essentially the timeline. And then the most recent look of reimbursement expenditure and DOE reimbursement activity in that third column. Again, the data as of

July 20th, ESSER 1, 2, and 3, you see the obligation deadlines. We finished up ESSER 1, of course, almost a year ago. ESSER 2 obligation deadline is looming just a couple of months out, September 30th, ESSER III, the last tranche following another year, 14 months out. You see

[05:35:09] the magnitude of the awarded formula funding for LEAs expended and reimbursed. Again, that third column is the actual submitted reimbursements and payments to school divisions and the balance and the percent remaining of the funding. And ESSER I, we finished with a fairly minimal balance of about a tenth of a percent under 300,000. Hold on. I'm going to bump into the presentation. I know Kent has me with remarks later, but I want to reiterate on this slide a couple of different

[05:35:45] things. These look like they're not spent, right? It looks like there's 20% of SR2 left. I actually have a spreadsheet that Kent's team produced for me last Friday that gives me percentages by school divisions. I started at the bottom of the five bottom school divisions, all five of them said oh no we spent the money we spent the money and then we like tracked it down they hadn't submitted their receipts for reimbursement so one of the things that I'm going to start doing is making those calls to all of our school divisions and helping them understand that this looks like you're not spending the money you have to submit those reimbursements

[05:36:24] and I think one of the challenges for our school divisions and I want to kind of defend our school divisions a little bit, our larger school divisions can submit weekly reimbursements. They have a large financial team. They have a large fiscal team. They can turn those records around. A lot of the school divisions I'm calling right now are very small school divisions. They don't have the staffing to do reimbursements on a regular cadence, and they do it two or three times a year. One district literally said to me, our entire fiscal team flipped in January. So we are building our team back up and then verifying our records to do our reimbursement. So that's why our numbers look that

[05:37:04] way. So we're going to talk more about this as Kent goes through the presentation. I want to do just a qualifier on this slide that while this data, it looks like we need to do a lot of work. I'm not sure the work we need to do is spend the money. I think we need to get better accounting to know where specifically we are and better understand where the expenditures have happened because I will be dedicating several hours a day next week calling all of our superintendents who are in those lower buckets of expenditures to help them understand how important it is to get

[05:37:39] the reimbursements through because I don't think we are visibly seeing what is actually happening on the expenditure side. What we're seeing is lack of accounting of the dollars and a lot of school divisions. A lot are fronting the money on their local budgets and then doing this reconciliation.

[05:37:57] And this is not just Virginia. This happened in Tennessee when I was there. And when I was talking with other state chiefs two weeks ago, this is an issue across the country. So this is something that is not unique to our school divisions. They got an influx of dollars. They didn't necessarily get an influx of fiscal staff to manage and do the reimbursement and the record to get the money reconciled correctly and that's where we need to lean in with our school divisions in particular because of the 7 the 9 30 23 date we need to help get that accelerated the records

[05:38:32] reconciliation is really an emphasis for us over the next month so just to be clear this is an accurate representation of those dollars or the um reimbursements that have been submitted thus far that yes ma'am yes yes when do the receipts have to be in for s or three you mean s or two because right now

we're in two oh we're on two okay okay 9 30 the 30th of september okay but that's three yeah and that's really the legal obligation to commit the funds really on a on a reimbursement

[05:39:07] basis do we would we go as far as we can but really we would we would go into december as late as december 31 but we you know we need several weeks to actual liquidate and draw down the funds but and we're like all states uh we're required to as a superintendent well knows file uh sr annual performance reports like all major formula grants um just some metrics uh that that are required

[05:39:38] federally, such as it is on the annual reports, and these lag. This data is only as of FY22, as that report finished up into the spring, so the data lags. But you can see in the federally designated broad categories of use, SESOR 1, 2, and 3, physical health and safety, quarter of the funds. Academic, social, emotional support, 38% mental health to operational continuity, 35%. A

[05:40:14] lot of that's maintaining current operations, current staffing, enhancing staffing in the support areas, school health, pupil transportation, bus aides, classroom aides, a number of support staff that were needed during the pandemic still needed tutors and learning law staff.

[05:40:37] And then on a same annual performance report metrics within those categories, sort of at an object level of expense, as you can imagine, you know, the highest type of expense in terms of, you know, object of expense per personnel and benefits, 35 percent.

[05:40:56] Materials, supplies, that was, of course, heavy during the pandemic, whether it was PPE or technology devices, hotspot devices, so forth, classroom materials for learning loss, purchase professional services, contractual services, a lot of that for temporary staffing, for tutors, for school health.

[05:41:21] So fairly heavy on the contractual staffing, then property items, equipment, much of that IT-related and other types of expenses.

[05:41:42] This particular slide, the data is a bit dated, but in response to a reporting requirement from the General Assembly, and we reported this data to them in the March/April timeframe once we completed the data collection, but really the issue the superintendent was speaking of to get a better sense of in comparison to how much DOE has actually reimbursed school divisions, what have they actually spent locally pending reimbursement, and what have they obligated

[05:42:21] firmly committed, you know, in contracts and payroll and programs. And they've got it queued up to be spent, but haven't reimbursed it. That was the data points the General Assembly was interested in. And again, you know, the look of this data would be significantly different because it's almost four to six months out. But the self-reported local spending, as well as the self-reported obligated funds were much higher, significantly higher than what we had reimbursed,

[05:42:56] as you would expect. And so the balance of funds on that basis was lower by tens of millions of dollars compared to what DOE had actually reimbursed in cash to LEAs. And this is a quick look at some of the data the General Assembly required. A couple of last metrics that's standard for states on the annual performance report. Some of the immediate uses that we had to report sort of in different time frames of the pandemic. The primary sort of immediate response were

[05:43:36] those things you would expect, PPE, ventilation, fiscal, rearranging classrooms, home internet access when schools were remote or virtual, then some of the attendance initiatives and family outreach

as schools were coming back. And then also required our FTEs, full-time equivalent employment. And of course, one purpose of the ESSER funds was to maintain local staffing

[05:44:10] in public schools maintain continuity of operations and states are were required to collect and report on total full-time equivalent staffing in the public schools just prior to during and coming out of the pandemic and you see some of that data and this this was state and federal monitoring to to to monitor the level of of staffing and any impact on staffing in the public schools, but you see over that four or five year time frame,

[05:44:47] total staffing actually grew, which consistent with the intent of pandemic funds to maintain staffing and operations. The 10% state set aside for state use, whether that's LEA awards, higher education projects, internal VDOE projects, and of course, state administration to service these grants. Here's a quick look here.

[05:45:26] Pretty much dovetails the actual utilization and drawdown and expenditure for these various uses from the state set aside again um uh the actual expenses and draw down lagging um what what's actually uh been been committed and obligated uh and many of these funds um most are have been awarded locally or to higher ed uh the same focus on uh emphasizing uh spending completion of

[05:45:59] projects and submitting reimbursements will will occur with these funds as well i'm gonna go backwards. So the same problem that we talked about with school divisions and getting those receipts and getting those reimbursements, a lot of the state set aside dollars are for contracted services. So our team also has to get the receipts and the invoices from the contracted services to get those, to get them invoiced so we can draw down. So one of the things I've asked the VDOE staff is to start pushing on vendors and providers that we're using for SR2 and SR3

[05:46:38] dollars to invoice us more frequently so that we can draw down and track our dollars more closely as well because we are facing the same situation similar to other state agencies same thing with our you know our little divisions if they're using a provider they need to be billed so that they can invoice so they can give us the receipt it's all of that billing processes that you're starting to see a slowdown across the country and the actual expenditure tracker and the percent remaining because it's not like a bank account. Everything's on a federal reimbursement, which is

[05:47:11] a challenge. So I want to qualify that there. But what I will say some states in our country have done is they've really devised trackers and public-facing trackers to push on those expenditures. And so one of the things you saw, the cool visualization team, they love me. I asked them to do. You asked them to do lots of things. I asked them. So one of the things I have asked them to do is to help us better visualize what we are doing, what we're spending our money on, where our money is being spent to help us all understand where we need to go. Because we're not giving money back,

[05:47:49] right? We need to spend our ESSER dollars. We need to reconcile it. I think for a small school division that may be fronting the money out of their own local budget, they don't want to get caught not being able to reimburse money and reconcile those dollars and we also don't want to revert any money back to the federal government so one thing that we are doing my favorite thing it's i like it even more than the teacher dashboard we have created we have the website but we are creating an actual dashboard someone changed that date i know i had september

[05:48:23] 1st on there. I know I wanted this dashboard by September 1st, but they left me. September 1st is when I want this dashboard, but the goal is to have a dashboard, and that's really small, to have a dashboard that actually tracks where we are, where our school divisions are, and where they are with their expenditures. So, that way it's very transparent for their community. It's very transparent to know where we are in ESSER spending. It also holds us all accountable to making sure those reimbursements go through, and we don't get stuck caught giving and reverting

[05:49:01] money back. But we also don't get stuck saying, oh, I thought I sent that reimbursement. It's not there. I thought, I have talked to more superintendents in the past several days who thought they were at 100% spend, and it was a very different rate up at the BDOE record keeping spaces so helping us be transparent in our record keeping in many states has been a very clear indication to help them get their books reconciled across their states many states are moving towards this dashboard and hopefully this dashboard will be up in september so we can start

[05:49:37] really seeing where those expenditures are where we're tracking what we're doing hi guys hi guys i know you're still here yeah paul had a moment when i said no i just want screenshots he was like oh good because he thought he was gonna have to come he's like lisa we're not ready to share this dashboard live yet um i i i remember there was a timeline but um very excited about some of these um screens that i'm going to give it back to kent to do the technical pieces but i wanted to give kind of the challenges that are happening with sr expenditures and the challenges

[05:50:13] and reporting in those kinds of spaces and what the actual fiscal challenges are and why a reimbursement system is very hard to report in real time. Because when you're doing those reimbursement cycles and when you're doing them at the local level and then they roll up and then the state has to do them as well, it's very hard to say this is the amount of money spent. Because if you went into a contract with a vendor, you also have to get invoiced by the vendor, you have to process that invoice, then you have to get reimbursed. So there is a lot of fiscal

[05:50:49] management. And I think that is the unseen challenge in a lot of places with the great gift of the ESR dollars is how to actually manage the spend down to make sure everybody understands what has actually been spent down and what pot of money it's actually coming out and how it's being reconciled. So this will be helpful. Kent, you want to talk about these really cool tools?

[05:51:13] Sure. Touch on about a half dozen sort of the main visual templates that are being developed. And I know this is awfully small. We can try to provide you a set of these that are blown up a bit, but essentially three components of the visual template, a state overview or state level look, essentially by ESSER 1, 2, and 3 is what we're tracking. Again, ESSER 1, we have closed out, but we'll report that data. And essentially at the state level for ESSER 2 and 3 going forward,

[05:51:53] formatted by allocation or award expenditure and remaining balance. And you can see at the bottom some part of this page, again, by the three tranches, ESSER 1, 2, and 3, that allocation balance spent format, average percent remaining, but we also are pulling in some student, basing it on a student basis using student enrollment.

[05:52:23] so you see the allocation per student, spent per student, balance per student, so it's standardized on a student-level basis, and that's more meaningful when we look at the division-level visuals. Then division, and this is unfiltered, this is really just queuing up this division-level format. This is populating it with state-level data. The end user using the dashboard would be

[05:52:57] able to call up one individual school division, but also multiple school divisions for comparison purposes. But again, this will bring up, again, this is on the second screen, state-level data, But you see the student demographic or student group categories, the total frequency counts of those student groups for context.

[05:53:23] And the bottom part, you see the allocation spent balance by grant award and then total as the very last bar chart. But then here, as a filtered view at the division level, and the example here is Culpeper County.

[05:53:43] That will call up their student group demographic data just for Culpeper County, and then their allocation spent and balance for ESSER 1, 2, and 3, and all funds totaled.

[05:54:02] An extension of the division view is a division comparison where in that same format, multiple school divisions can be brought up in this format.

[05:54:17] And when they are, and this is a comparison of several locations, or actually just queuing up Culpeper County, but then in addition, as a comparative group, Culpeper County, Chesterfield, Henrico County in Richmond City.

[05:54:43] So in close proximity visually, you see a comparison across three tranches of grant funding, comparative analysis across multiple localities that can be brought up for comparative purposes.

[05:55:01] You see the raw dollars, the per student metrics there, and you see things nicely compared on a bar chart basis as well. So, you know, really the format for this, when it goes live, will be statewide, individual division, visual look, and then a division comparison type filter as well.

[05:55:27] Can you hold just one second, please? Mr. Hanson, he has a couple of questions. Lisa, thank you so much for your team's efforts. this is incredibly helpful to get a wholesome view of all this i have a couple of questions on slide five um with the unexpended balances for esser two and for esser three

[05:56:02] are the restrictions or parameters of what those dollars can be spent on and this may be gonna suggestive point of view that with the learning loss of our NAICS scores I know that with a lot of the funds that were spent in the middle of the pandemic for personnel and safety and computers and whatnot we're just surviving through it but at this point in time

[05:56:36] maybe just tell me of what um are the parameters of what that 170 million and 1.1 billion can be spent on yeah i just want to reiterate these aren't unspent they're unreimbursed so i would say a lot more spent um than reimbursed and i just want to clarify that it says balance but it's the balance reimbursed versus the balance spent um i definitely we have federal guidelines we have challenges in putting additional parameters from a state level on those federal spaces but we are definitely starting to signal and definitely as i said earlier those phone calls

[05:57:16] that i'm making to superintendents around their unspent dollars will be signaling the importance of learning acceleration and spending those dollars on those kinds of items lisa also maybe just forwarding to slide 10 with uh the state um set aside yeah um maybe just tell you understand if you're not ready for prime time if it hasn't been discerned yet but what are you looking to do with those yep most of those funds are in contract so they're in active contracts for example we have

[05:57:55] an active contract around grow your own so those are grow your some of those are grow your own dollars that are active contracts that people haven't asked for reimbursement yet so a lot of those

dollars are active contracts we have about five million dollars that we are um using for contracts that won't be spent now then i know for a fact that we have five million dollars to actively spend we'll be putting those around attendance and teacher pipeline development issues to make sure we are adequately staffing areas as you talked about learning loss and

[05:58:30] demographics we have areas with high numbers of provisional or international teachers that we need to build up some grow your own programs and to develop the teacher pipeline in particular areas i know region eight is one in particular where they're having significant staffing needs from the visualization you saw earlier region two we really need to tailor some of our teacher your pipeline development dollars and increase those to make sure that we have highly qualified teachers for our students. So right now, those are the two areas we have in process. I'm going

[05:59:07] to say this correctly, two RFPs for learning loss content for reading and mathematics that will be released here in the next several weeks. They're in process. I believe they're with procurement right now to release to become available so that we can provide statewide literacy and statewide math content for support and learning acceleration so we are definitely moving the needle forward as we've talked earlier our buckets of current spending are around attendance around teacher pipeline development and around learning loss a majority of our funds when sr2 is allocated out

[05:59:45] will be towards learning loss and an even larger portion of ESSER III will be tagged for learning loss type activities. But I'm happy to provide at our next board meeting specific tags around dollars and percentages if that would be helpful. Thank you. And one last question is, and just thank you for the dashboards and the transparency here. Maybe just also as we're looking forward down the road a little bit from an accountability standpoint to really also um i know we're going

[06:00:23] to be able to quantify where the dollars were spent um that um maybe the roi on the three billion dollars that was distributed to districts in the 300 plus million at the state level and again these are unprecedented dollars and it would be i think helpful especially in light of the headwinds on student achievement and everything else that we've been facing to really try to um quantify as best we can and i know a lot of this is going to be infrastructure

[06:00:58] and you know maintenance and other things but um i i think not just tracking the dollars but understanding what the roi was as best we can and again not all of it but in certain areas and i not sure if the u.s department of education is going to try to be undergoing such an effort but i just think it would be a helpful exercise for us to try to understand um what worked what didn't work lessons learned um not that we ever want to experience anything like this again but it would

[06:01:36] just i think be helpful to know you know maybe you know the first couple of ways weren't um we're We're just, again, really keeping our head above water, but this last half of these funds in particular, if we can, any way to show any type of an ROI on them.

[06:01:55] Yeah, I think that's really important to me as well, because we want to make sure that we are driving our dollars to our students and their achievement. One of the things that we've talked about, Dave Myers, who works very closely with Paul and his team as well, is that the data doesn't speak to each other.

[06:02:13] So when you want to look at the achievement data and the expenditure data, you have to do all of those crosswalks and the interoperability because you're talking about two separate, not Maserati systems. So one of the things we've run into and one of the things we're trying to look at with things like

this dashboard and things like what Paul showed is how do we get our systems to talk to each other so we can actually determine return on investment, right?

[06:02:39] Because if we can say this is how we spent the money and this is what we can say in achievement, those two systems have to talk to each other so you can crosswalk it over and not do, you know, Spanish to French translations. And that's one of the challenges that we're starting to run into when we really look at those investment dollars and how those investment dollars transition to student achievement is you are managing multiple systems and trying to get them to talk to each other.

[06:03:04] but i agree 100 that's that's a big challenge but it's an important challenge for us to figure out because it is an unprecedented investment and we want to make sure that we're moving the needle for our kiddos thank you oh i'm sorry over here oh i'm sorry thank you just along those same lines i mean oh man we've got to hurry up and spend it i mean the whole nation's in the same boat right we're going to hurry up and spend it in a year i mean they wouldn't give us any more time to spend the money um and then in a year it all goes bye-bye and

[06:03:43] everybody faces a fiscal cliff. So I guess, you know, we had to hire all these people, right, because we had to spend the money. 35% of Virginia went to personnel and benefits, which makes sense. You know, Marguerite Rosa, many other people around the country tried to come out with smart ways to spend it that don't rely on more people that you're inevitably going to have to let go a lot of these people in a year. So I guess one thing I'd love for us to be thinking about, and I'm sure you are I hear what you're saying um is about how do we come up with sustainable um learning loss

[06:04:18] catch up what do you want to call interventions and don't rely on all these staffing that we have now but we're not going to have in a year or you know what I mean it's it's just the incentives around this unprecedented amount of funding are really tough you know I don't I don't still don't understand in my mind why they didn't give uh localities and states more time to spend the But anyway, how are you thinking about this huge inflection of new staff, and then they got to go they got to go bye-bye?

[06:04:46] Do you want me to answer that? or do you want to keep asking questions? Dr. Siebert? I think maybe I can use help a little bit from again. This is not representative of the State. The big money is in the big districts.

[06:05:01] But you know in the in the smaller, you know, region 6, 7, 8 area. I just couple things. I'll say take heart. Look how Esther 1 was expended now a tenth of a percent of a much bigger pot is still gonna be big money. money. But take heart, ESSER-1. I think everybody worked real hard to do it. I think these tools are going to be very, very helpful and appreciated, and that's going to be a very good thing. So thank you, Kent, and thank you. You're just killing lots of things, and this is another one of those, so we appreciate you for that. So there's a couple of different trajectories here.

[06:05:34] As Mr. Hanson pointed out, you know, originally there was the PPE, and then it was the technology, and those things you spent and happened. But then there are these staffing pieces, and this is also So to truly have a glide path, I think there's going to be some divisions are going to have a cliff. I think most of the ones I've talked to have worked very hard on a glide path.

[06:05:52] And I'll can't hear that glide path has been made more difficult by the budget impasse, because the goal was, you know, what we were expecting, even from the House and Senate budgets, was going to increase state funding to a point that's going to take some of the pressure off of what ESSER funds are

being used for. So that's why we're still hoping that August, September, we can get a budget compromise from Reconvened General Assembly, because that will help with the trajectories that divisions were working on.

[06:06:16] So you have PPE and technology, but actually, you know, you want to change lives, you need people. You know, it's a caring, committed professional, an instructional assistant, a teacher, a specialist that's going to help with learning loss. And part of that is people who are going to be teaching all this coming year, 22, 23, 24.

[06:06:33] and because when we teach in 23-24 those expenses are going to be slowly over the school year and they're not going to be actualized and reimbursed until end of september next year by december next year so that big pot so so there are people out there and that's why again the state budgeting pass helps give you that that that that glide path but um i i do think if you look at sr one it was spent investing perfectly the other thing to think about is because of the longer timeline with the bigger pot of money and s or three that actually gave divisions that i'm familiar with the opportunity to plan to use it thoughtfully to use your actual budgeting planning study processes

[06:07:12] and so there's absolutely plenty of money being invested in learning loss a lot of that is with people serving children but then the other thing prudent thing for a divisional locality to do is say this is short-term money and it's big how can we get long-term benefit and so that's where you saw the capital progress of the air conditioning base hcc and some of the facilities things are happening and those also took a longer time to spin up design bid build and encumber and i think you're going to see those expenses hit toward the very end as well so i i i think i i i i feel a pretty high degree of confidence that people are doing good work in the field but i do think that

[06:07:50] when when all federal even those of us are familiar with title one and perkins all these lagging federal grants that are reimbursement based are always lagging and it's a real hard thing to keep your finger on um but i i do so those are some of the factors just want to give you the the local context you'll have more in the presentation or did we take your did the questions take over your presentation i think we got through all the material thank you thank you thank you okay

[06:08:28] so we have now moved to discussion of current issues does anyone have discussion of current issues that they need to bring up dr siever i'd like to lay back but i do want to get on the road um we know and i just want to know people who still still tuned in and i've learned over the past year serving the board that lots of people watch our meetings after the fact and so this is important part of the process we had an excellent retreat on tuesday uh normally a retreat would be off-site off-site doesn't mean it would be a resort we were planning to view it at a school and the school would have been a fun place to do it but there was going to be marching band which

[06:09:05] is i fully regard but it was going there were complications there and as such retreats historically apparently have not been been broadcast so i do want to just kind of go on the record with the public and then invite the board and superintendent to chime in on the what i thought was one of lots of good stuff but especially for me and the passions that that my colleagues are constantly talking about is modernizing assessment accountability and we've talked the past year a lot about this bifurcation of assessment from accountability and we lots of good conversations were there so we we gave the superstition a long list we i think people can expect that reports and information will be coming and and we're going to really be working hard on

[06:09:45] this and there's lots of moving pieces and they're being coordinated well the kind of timely one in that robust discussion that we had this year on tuesday was my desire and and dr coons if you want elaborate on this and what ideas maybe you've had but my my desire would be at least it's worth a look i don't know anything can be done but i'd like for staff and our legal counsel to look at delegate coiners house bill 2027 which was the statutory initiation for three-year growth assessments i like to have those looked at because we learned here in the spring that the 22 23 three

[06:10:24] year growth assessments did not achieve what we thought they would do could not help in the way they did but they still had all of the challenges of uh implementation so perhaps you know if because the bill didn't require a particular tool maybe there's flexibility for the department maybe for the board to to provide some sort of reprieve to to school divisions in school year 23 24 which many are already open and up and running but if there's a way we could restore some instructional significant instructional time um by by looking at that process using it through a growth assessment

[06:10:59] so again it might be option one might be schools go ahead and do what you did last year you did it you know how it works you'll get the data you got etc but if there's a way that maybe schools could probably still want to use grade three so they could have started your end of the year for the growth pete of our kind of still here soon be probably legacy accountability system um but But maybe in other grades, using the school test identifier, schools could use an approved set of tools where they would report growth out.

[06:11:27] Now, I know this challenge is comparability, and maybe VBOS can help with that. I just, I would like to have a look. It has to happen fast. We're looking to schedule a special August meeting anyway. So, the answer might be, looked at it, impossible. Looked at it, grand slam.

[06:11:43] Looked at it, we can do a few things like that. Dr. Siebert, you are speaking the language of your colleagues, because I have had the opportunity to speak with all eight regional superintendents, groups about assessment and accountability, and I would say at least in every single conversation, we spent about a third of the time talking about growth, talking about the importance of growth, as we talked about on Tuesday, really understanding where a student is and where we took them, whether it's a gifted student at the top end of the spectrum,

[06:12:20] a student who is struggling a student who is really struggling we heard a lot about really making sure that we are treating our most fragile students and ensuring they have opportunities to grow i think growth is a pivotal moment for us to be having a conversation about around accountability and our superintendents have been very clear with me that the the legislation did not bring what they thought it would bring to instruction and that they also feel like growth is the most transparent measure of accountability because it truly gets at where every child is going and how we're doing with every child in collaboration with an achievement of where we

[06:12:56] want to go so i think it's important for us to continue to look at and solve growth i also have heard about the amount of time that the current growth assessment takes away from instruction and it's delivered in a secure tested environment similar to a summative assessment and it is not delivered in a way that gives instructional feedback to educators, which was the hope and intent of the legislation. I think what we have to determine is, as you mentioned, it is a couple of business days till August. I visited a school opening on Monday, so there are already schools

[06:13:34] that are in session right now and helping us figure out if there is a possibility to get solutions very quickly for our school districts within our statutory, but also our technical capacity and ability to do that and meet those expectations. I know we've had a preliminary conversation with the Attorney General, and they have committed to look at the legislation and the flexibility that we have. I think for the department, we will have to go back to our current assessment vendor who is contracted to do that growth year and that three-year growth assessment one to see what flexibilities we have in the actual delivery and design and see if we

[06:14:13] can make that more of a formative approach to see if there's an opportunity to give relief as to using that formal growth assessment as a mandate and give options i don't know what the statute story components are and i don't know what the flexibility is but i'm more than happy to do that because i think the legislative intent was to give a tool that gave instructional feedback and truly got at that growth. I do want to mention that there are multiple states across the country using a value-added model. We have a SAS value-added model. We used Vivos for the first time

[06:14:50] to give parents information in the spring. This year, there are a lot of components of that that would not add testing. It would add psychometric analysis to the existing testing and be able to possibly give us some growth information there. So happy to bring all of those things back to you and get some quick information as much as possible.

[06:15:11] We can also provide summary reports and information in those weekly reports that you get via email in preparation for a conversation on the special call meeting in August, if that would be helpful. I'm definitely committed to doing whatever we can to make assessment for learning and assessment purposeful for our children.

[06:15:32] I just don't know what not only boundaries legally, what boundaries we have practically to make sure we can turn a solution like this quickly but i'm happy to commit to that and as soon as you realize the juice isn't worth the squeeze please stop the juice for children is always worth the squeeze uh any other current issues that want that board members would like to discuss this before we adjourn i guess yes yeah i have one madam president yes sir um public

[06:16:07] comment is vitally important and i'm thankful that we had a lot of people doing public comment today. I'm thankful that a couple of organizations came forward doing public comment, wanting to partner with our board. Those two organizations, the Virginia Association of School Superintendents and the Virginia School Boards Association, with their willingness to partner with our board. I think that's going to be valuable. Also know that the three additions that we have to this board, we've got a boost. It's been a pleasure to work with the first two, and I'm looking forward to

[06:16:43] working for number three when she arrives. Leadership matters. Leadership matters. And what do I mean by that? Under our new leadership, Madam President, Grace, and Bill, from day one of leadership, we have a timer. We have an energy. We're on track. So I do look forward to working with you, Madam President, and Bill, and your Vice President capacity. And this board is dedicated I appreciate it to a good discussion always like the discussion with Miss Holton.

[06:17:19] She brings a lot of value and experience to this board, and I know what the different levels of experience and talent that we have. We're gonna get some things done. Thank you, my president. Yes, sir. Anybody else? Oh, Miss Holton.

[06:17:38] I'd just like to say I reiterate that I thought we've had a really good meeting this week. I understand why we didn't televise the meetings on Tuesday because that was meant to be a retreat day offsite, but I'm sorry we didn't because we had such good productive discussions. On the standards of quality on the accreditation accountability issues we did talk about possibly getting moving on a Nora.

[06:18:03] To get the regulatory process begun on accountability and assessment, we talked about some of the work going on with the task force behind the scenes on on assessment. We talked about on the standards of quality. We talked about getting some national speakers in to help inform our work.

[06:18:21] We did talk about scheduling potentially a special meeting in August, and I think there's a poll going on, but I hope it's okay to share for the public's sake that I think dates of August 30th and 31st are being floated, that no decisions have been made unless something, I haven't checked my email lately, but it was a really good and productive day.

[06:18:42] I do hope sort of going forward, I just like one thing we didn't get to this week that I thought we just had a lot on our plate, but one important item we didn't get to is the beginning of the comprehensive plan. And, you know, that document, you know, it's a 40 some page document traditionally, that's the five year plan and it will give a, but boiled down to three priorities in the prior one.

[06:19:06] So 40 pages of a lot of required data for the mandate, meet the mandate of the statute but having three or four or five things that we all agree are what we're going to work hard on over the next five years is a really helpful exercise and so i hope we have the chance to get started on that soon we just plain ran out of time and maybe everybody can take a look at the prior one i'll uh i think i sent the link to the superintendent the um um

[06:19:41] the um i i do hope we we did get some public input on the soqs um uh this week i don't know that we've gotten any on the comprehensive plan yet uh but i do hope that we have the opportunity to get more public input you mentioned uh uh mr sturdon sort of in a couple of key stakeholder groups. And I know we have heard from them a little bit on those SOQs, but I hope we hear from them and others on comprehensive plan. And it may even be that we want to figure out between our August and September meeting, do we want to set aside some time to hear

[06:20:16] specifically from the general public and or the stakeholder groups about those really important topics um as we go forward or otherwise uh set up a portal or something to to seek public input on that um i'm going off to the 6 30 math um uh standards hearing in fredericksburg today i know others have had an opportunity to do some of those we are getting some input on that and on that i did flag to dr coons the thing i'm hearing most in the written comments and in the meetings is

[06:20:51] questions about how do we do this crosswalk year or how do we avoid unnecessary delay but also unreasonable expectations on teachers for this school year and i know you're working hard on solutions on that and look forward to hearing um how we can go forward so thank you uh for everything we did get done and everything we're gonna get done anyone else okay i'll take a motion

[06:21:25] to adjourn so moved second all right we're out good job



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